12 PERSPECTIVES ON PLAYFUL LEARNING IN SOCIAL EDUCATION AND TEACHER EDUCATION

EDITED BY
HELLE MARIE SKOVBJERG

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PRE

BY HELLE MARIE SKOVBJERG

Head of Research and Professor at Kolding School of Design

FACE

Well-being crisis. Climate crisis. Economic crisis. Crisis crisis. We live in a time of seemingly endless crises. This calls for new solutions to the huge challenges facing society today – and for the willingness and ability to explore new paths. Are we looking for solutions to the right problems? Are these the solutions we want to signpost our future? The professional practices of social educators and teachers are absolutely key to equipping our children and young people for a future where imaginative and creative powers will come to play a crucial role.

What if? Play and playfulness are crucial to our dreams, hopes and beliefs and how we imagine multiple worlds, many ways of living and numerous possible answers and questions for the future.

Play is a fundamental part of being human. Play takes a variety of shapes and forms throughout our lives, and it is important that we take an interest in the multifacetedness of play and playfulness and turn our attention to the details, the empirical evidence and the diversity of theoretical approaches to play, allowing us to demonstrate the importance of play and playfulness in our lives.

In pedagogy and education, we define play and playfulness through the special play qualities that we can draw on to create pedagogical environments that are interesting, relevant and inspiring for children and young people. We can use qualities from role play – like imagining that we are playing a role and telling a story – to teach a particular topic. Or we can ensure that kindergarten children experience all the qualities associated with rough-and-tumble play in the playground.

The 12 perspectives

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This publication presents 12 perspectives on playful approaches to teaching and learning in social education and teacher education in Denmark. The 12 articles reflect the essential versatility of our work with play and playfulness. Also, it highlights the specific ways in which the social educators and teachers of tomorrow work with playfulness in their professional practice.

The publication draws on 12 PhD projects on playful approaches to professional didactics in social education and teacher education. The projects are part of the Playful Learning Research Extension, a research collaboration between the LEGO Foundation and Denmark's six university colleges.

The publication is written for educators and students on the social education and teacher education programmes. Several of the perspectives are also relevant to other degree programmes and in practice. You can read about specific didactic designs that you can try out, about relevant theories on playful learning and about a conversation with a teddy by the name of Shoelace.

We hope that the publication will contribute to building a greater understanding of the professional competences of social educators and teachers. Competences that allow them to meet children with the question of "what if", to unleash their imaginative and creative powers and to ensure that subject-matter and professional practices go hand in hand with experimentation and exploration.

Children and young people must be met by adults who are ready to wonder and to co-create with them.

Happy reading! I hope that this is just the beginning of a lively conversation about play and playfulness – now and in the future.

Huge thanks go to the educators and students at all six university colleges in Denmark for their contributions to the project. We would also like to thank PhD supervisors, PhD co-supervisors, Kolding School of Design, Aarhus University and Aalborg University as well as international partners who have supported the research project over the years.

P1

THE BACKSTAGE DESIGN

– a playful approach to explicitly give reasons for practices in Danish university college PlayLabs

BY TINA VISGAARD DUEDAHL

Tina Visgaard Duedahl, Associate Professor and PhD student at UCL University College. This article is based on Duedahl's PhD project: Udvikling af andenordensdidaktisk praksis i læreruddannelsens PlayLabs (Development of second-order didactic practices in Danish university college PlayLabs).

Based on my PhD project *Udvikling af andenordensdidaktisk praksis i læreruddannelsens PlayLabs* (Duedahl, 2024), in this article I will describe how, in collaboration with educators teaching Danish on the teacher education programmes, I have developed the 'backstage' design. The design supports teacher educators explicitly explaining their teaching practices in a dialogue with the students.

The design invites the students backstage and gives them access to the educator's didactic reflections and reasons. In the dialogue, the students gain experience with *thinking* and *talking* like a teacher, which, from the point of view of preparing them for their future professional roles, develops their ability to plan, execute and evaluate teaching practices in schools in a reasoned manner.

Part of the object of teacher education programmes is to prepare the students for their *own* role as teachers. It is well known that teachers often teach on the basis of their own experience and the way they were taught themselves (e.g. Lortie, 1975; Cochran-Smith & Zeichner, 2005; Oettingen & Jensen, 2017; Iskov, 2020), and so the teaching on the teacher education programmes should be worth learning (to teach) from for the students. In the project, this is referred to as second-order teaching practices (Iskov, 2020) – practices that must also constitute an ideal for – and be an established practice – in the PlayLabs in teacher education.

PlayLabs and development of practice

PlayLabs have been established at all the university colleges in Denmark in connection with the Playful Learning development project (2018-2022), and they differ from ordinary classrooms, among other things because of their materiality and pedagogical intentions. Featuring, for example, large, open and transparent spaces, stages, stairs you can sit on, caves as well as various forms of technology and reusable materials, the architecture, interiors and artifacts create materially changed conditions for the teaching. These changed conditions go hand in hand with a pedagogical ideal and intention of promoting playful approaches to teaching and learning on the teacher education programmes.

However, the initial analyses in my PhD project showed that, in this respect, the teacher educators 1) predominantly reproduced practices associated with teaching in the ordinary classrooms (e.g. through the use of chairs, tables, PCs and PowerPoint presentations), and that they 2) did not explicitly give reasons for their practice (e.g. the choice of using PlayLab to work with the Danish subject content) (Duedahl, 2022).

In my PhD project, I expand the concepts of second-order teaching practices (Iskov,

2020) in the context of the university college PlayLabs (Duedahl & Iskov, 2024; Duedahl, 2024), and, based on the expanded concepts, seven didactic designs are developed in an iterative and co-creative process with teacher educators. These designs support teaching practices in which the teacher educators:

- SHOW and invite the students to participate in a practice that is aligned with the relationship between the material *conditions* (PlayLab), *decisions* (tangible actions) and *arguments* (pedagogical ideals) of the teaching;
- TALK about and present explicit *arguments* for the practice being aligned and relevant to the students' future practice as schoolteachers;
- TUNE INTO exploring and developing practices together with the students through various *bodily expressions* and *moods*.

Six of the seven designs (1-6) support the teacher educators in showing and inviting the students to participate in a practice that is *aligned* and *in tune with* the teaching of Danish as a subject (word classes, proverbs and figures of speech, rhetoric, poetry slam and audio narratives). While these designs are talked about in other contexts (Duedahl, 2024; Duedahl & Iskov, 2024), this article concentrates on the seventh design (7): the backstage design. This design supports teacher educators in talking about and explicitly giving reasons for the use of this practice in dialogues with the students.

A design-based and practice-theoretical approach

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The PhD project is rooted in Design-Based Research (DBR) (Bakker, 2018) and involves problem-driven research, where, in an iterative and co-creative process with five teacher educators, I have, among other things, developed a number of design principles and didactic designs aimed at supporting the change in practice.

From a practice theory perspective (Kemmis et al., 2014), we have, through the design-based process, developed seven designs that create material, linguistic and social changes in the practice architecture. Changes that give rise to a new practice – understood as new actions: new ways of thinking, speaking, acting and relating in teaching (Duedahl, 2024).

As shown in the following sections on the backstage design, the design gives rise to, for example, a new practice by:

- (materially) making it legitimate for the students to raise didactic issues with their educators;
- (linguistically) supporting new ways of thinking and talking about teaching practices;
- (socially) inviting educators and students to relate to each other in changing roles and moods, which breaks away from the traditional asymmetry of professional relationships.

The backstage design

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The backstage design has been developed together with Rikke Bundsgaard, who is an associate professor in Danish and has participated in the PhD project as a teacher educator.

The design consists of a deck of cards, an accompanying guide, a *timer* and a *buzzer*. The cards encourage the students to ask didactic questions and invite the educator to enter into a dialogue on their shared practice. The

buzzer makes it possible to 'freeze-frame' the teaching – to put it on hold – while the timer keeps the educator and the students reflecting on the current teaching practice.

At the beginning of the class, the students each draw one of the following cards:

THE MAIN CARD (4 cards). This supports four students in raising questions about one of four themes. One student asks about reflections on and arguments for the use of *PlayLab's materiality*, one asks about the specific *actions* that are taken in the teaching, one asks about the *social relations* of the teaching, and one asks what relevance the teaching has for their future practice as *schoolteachers*. This could, for example, be questions such as:

- How are PlayLab's architecture, interiors and artifacts used in the teaching, and why?
- What bodily actions do you/we perform in PlayLab that differ from teaching in ordinary classrooms, and why?
- How does PlayLab affect the relationships and power relations that exist in the teaching, and how does it feel?
- Does the way we interact here also have qualities in the schools, and why?

The intention is for the questions to invite a dialogue on how the decisions, conditions and arguments of the teaching are aligned.

THE JOKER CARD (2 cards). These cards support two students in independently formulating questions based on the situated practice, sudden impulses and what may interest them in the situation. The intention is to make room for the unpredictable.

PARTICIPATION CARD (34 cards). These cards support the other students in participating actively in the dialogue when it arises by asking follow-up and explanatory questions such as:

- Could you try to elaborate on what you mean when you say ...?
- Can you give an example?
- What were you thinking when...?

The intention is to prolong and add nuance to the dialogue as well as to create opportunities for participation and polyphonic dialogues.

The change in practice

—

On the basis of video observations and interviews (Davidsen & Kjær, 2018; Kvale, 1997) as well as reflexive thematic analyses (Braun & Clarke, 2012), my PhD project shows that the design creates a changed practice in the form of new actions – new ways of thinking, talking, acting and relating in the classroom (Duedahl & Iskov, 2024; Duedahl, 2024). The following quotations are taken from parts of the empirical data that are not included in the PhD dissertation.

The students raise didactic questions, are let in on the educators' didactic thinking and become active participants in dialogues in which they reflect on, argue for and develop the teaching practices together with their educators. The teacher educators are open, explorative and experimental in their reflections on – and the development of – their own practice. As knowledge authorities in the dialogue (and role models for the students), they explain, using theoretical and experience-based knowledge, how practice is aligned and relevant to the students' future practice as schoolteachers. The students provide possible reasons and follow-up questions, also in continuation of each other, thus resulting in a polyphonic dialogue in which educators and students together explore their shared practice.

The teacher educators describe this as a new and changed practice: "Well, I was convinced that I was already having these dialogues with my students, but I can see that this is quite different, and I can also learn a lot from it." The students also say that they are not used to such dialogues. In practice, this is, for example, evident from the fact that the joker card, which allows students to ask any questions they want, is rarely used the first times the design is tried. According to the students, it can be difficult to come up with questions, and they point out that the design supports the change in practice: "If you don't know what to ask about, it's difficult to ask the questions, so it's helpful that we now have these cards."

Over time, the intention is for the changed practice – the new actions – to become embedded into the practice tradition on the teacher education programmes. In the words of one of the students, this will mean that the design will no longer be needed: "(...) once it has been used once, let's say once it has been used three times, then you start to think for yourself, don't you, and after some time we will then perhaps not need these cards anymore."

The new practice is vulnerable

—

My PhD project shows that teacher educators feel vulnerable when having to explicitly reflect on and give reasons for their teaching practice in dialogues with the students. This must be seen in the light of the new actions. For example, the teacher educators' didactic arguments are laid bare, they become open to negotiation, and any didactic doubts become apparent (Duedahl, 2024).

The vulnerability is reflected, for example, in the bodily actions of the teacher educators when the design is used. When questions are raised by the student teachers, the teacher educators may react, for example, by spinning around, bending backwards, staring at the ceiling, picking up a ball from the floor, throwing it again and swinging their heads and legs from side to side. The physical reactions are accompanied by laughter. Like in this situation, where a student asks:

Well, I was just thinking: what forms of teaching and working methods are we actually using in the classroom, and why? (Both teacher educators bend over laughing with their hands resting on their knees.)

The teacher educators also laugh when responding to the students' questions employing humour and ironic distance by, for example, saying: "Wow, that's a brilliant question", "What a completely spontaneous question", "You've really been pondering that one, haven't you" and "Yes, cool".

The new actions are described in my PhD project as "silliness" (Duedahl, 2014), and they are interpreted as a play practice that contributes to creating an atmosphere that is alternately characterised by tension, elevation and euphoria (Karoff, 2013). This play practice is interpreted as a sign that the new teaching practice is felt by the educators to be uncomfortable and embarrassing. The teacher educators themselves describe the new practice as "artificial" and use words such as "defence" to describe their ways of reacting (Duedahl, 2024).

In developing the design, steps have been taken to reduce the vulnerability of both educators and students. For example, it is stated as a fundamental principle in the guide that the design supports appreciative *reflections*

on and not critical *assessments* of practice« (Duedahl, 2024). However, it is important to stress that pedagogical practices (also without the design) are associated with dilemmas, paradoxes and doubts. From the point of view of preparing the students for their future professional lives, it is therefore important that the design helps to draw the attention of the students to these dilemmas etc. It is thus regarded as a strength that the educators are open and vulnerable, and that they show and tell the students that it is perfectly normal to have doubts and to not necessarily be able to explain your didactic choices.

Playfulness as a catalyst for change in practice

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In my research, playfulness manifests itself as a catalyst of change in practice – by acting as a 'collective consent' between the participants (Duedahl, 2024). In the initial analyses, we interpreted the silliness as actions that undermined the legitimacy and potential of the design. But we subsequently learned that it is precisely the silliness that, as a collective consent, establishes a bond between educators and students in a joint transgression of the existing practice, and gives them the courage to do so.

The silliness constitutes a brief temporal phase, and it marks a shift – a transition – from one practice to another. In other words, the project shows that playfulness is what makes it possible for educators and students to fully engage in the new 'artificial' practice rather than form a distaste for it, vote against it and/or withdraw from it. Playfulness thus becomes concurrently a *reflection* of the change in practice itself and *what* makes it possible.

As a consequence of this realisation, the 'silliness' is highlighted in the design and thus in the development of the second-order teaching practice. For example, the buzzer is included to mark the transgression of the existing practice and the shift to the artificial. It is also specified in the guide that silliness is a fundamental principle that supports educators and students in tuning in to and together exploring and developing practice through changing bodily expressions and moods.

New didactics

—

My PhD project proposes a new approach to teaching in the PlayLabs on the teacher education programmes – a new didactic practice. The potential of the backstage design is that it can more generally support the development of an explicitly justified teaching practice in teacher education. Students, teacher educators and university college management all see a potential in the further development of the design for use in the ordinary classrooms of the teacher education programmes. This further development is already happening. The ambition is also for the design to become part of and support the development of the teaching practices of the university colleges more generally. The design is already attracting interest from the social education programmes and assistant professor programmes aimed at associate professor qualification.

Do you want to try the design?

—

Contact Tina Visgaard Duedahl and Rikke Bundsgaard.

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P2

PLAY MEANS TO GO OUT, PRACTISE MEANS TO TAKE SOMETHING IN

– on the relationship between play and practice

BY SØREN HØRNING HANSEN

Søren Hørning Hansen, PhD from VIA University College and educator at UCL University College. This article is based on Hansen's PhD project: Metaforer for leg og øvelse – En metaforteoretisk undersøgelse af forholdet mellem leg og øvelse (Metaphors for Play and Practice – A Metaphorical Study of the Relationship Between Play and Practice).

It is interesting to look into our understanding of the relationship between play and practice – how these two activity concepts can be seen as both related and different. There are two reasons for this. Firstly, both play and practice (or 'training tracks') have become two important themes on the social and teacher education programmes. However, to my knowledge, the two themes have not yet been thought of as being interrelated, but rather are seen as two separate thematic tracks. Secondly, it is a common view in expertise research that play and practice are activity concepts that denote different methods or strategies for the acquisition of skills and, in the long term, also expertise. One would therefore expect the question of how we understand the relationship between play and practice to be important for our understanding of how people acquire skills and expertise.

But even though there is every reason to be curious about the relationship between play and practice, there is just one problem. Existing theories about the relationship between play and practice are both theoretically and methodologically deficient. The theoretical deficiencies concern the fact that existing theories predominantly address how play and practice are different, and not how they can be seen as being interrelated. The methodological deficiencies are due to the fact that the existing theories do not describe exactly how they have arrived at these theoretical perspectives on the relationship between play and practice. The existing theories about the relationship between play and practice are thus hardly mature enough to be called scientific. From my perspective, in order for a theory to be scientific, it must describe a method that researchers can use to verify the theory.

In my PhD thesis, which is titled *Metaforer for leg og øvelse – En metaforteoretisk undersøgelse af forholdet mellem leg og øvelse*, I use everyday language metaphors for play and practice in an attempt to develop a scientific method for theorising about the relationship between play and practice, i.e. for theorising on how these two activity concepts can be seen as both related and different.

In this article, I want to give a taste of how the method can help us reflect on the relationship between play and practice, i.e. how these two activity concepts can be viewed as both related and different.

How the method is theoretically based on Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory

The idea that everyday language should be able to make us wiser about play and practice may sound like a strange proposition. However, the metaphor theory developed by cognitive scientists George Lakoff and Mark Johnson (1980; 1999) argues that the concep-

tual metaphors of everyday language are not just linguistic phenomena. They are pervasive in our way of thinking and experiencing the world. Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory focuses on metaphors in everyday language, i.e. the metaphors we use on a daily basis, and which we therefore often do not pay particular attention to or think much about.

Thinking and bodily experience

In my thesis, I identify two core points in Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory. The first point is that metaphors are not primarily about language, but about thought. Lakoff and Johnson go against the common understanding of metaphor as being about language, especially poetic language. Rather than being confined to poetic language, metaphor is understood by Lakoff and Johnson as being fundamental to human thinking, as key to our understanding of the world. In *Metaphors We Live By*, they describe metaphor as a tool we use to understand a difficult concept by associating it with more easily understandable concept (Lakoff & Johnson, 1980). In *Philosophy in the Flesh*, they explain this further by saying that we use concepts linked to sensorimotor experiences to understand concepts linked to subjective experiences and judgments (Lakoff and Johnson, 1999).

The second point is that the metaphors we use to think do not arise by chance, but rather are rooted in the bodily experiences we have on a daily basis. More precisely, their point is that the metaphors are grounded in 'experiential correspondence' between the two paired concepts of a metaphor.

Happiness as an example

The above two points are hard to grasp without exemplification, so let me present one of the many everyday language metaphors used as an example by Lakoff and Johnson, namely the everyday language metaphor that they call HAPPY IS UP. Lakoff and Johnson focus on English everyday language, but we also know this metaphor in Danish. In Danish we may, for example, talk about happiness (*lykke*) as something that is associated with feeling 'up' (*oppe*), feeling 'in high spirits' (*optur*), and the opposite of happiness (sadness (*tristhed*)) as something that is associated with feeling 'down' or 'low' (*nedtrykt/nedtrykt/helt nede i kulkælderen*).

This metaphor can be used to illustrate the above two key points from Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory. According to their first point, the metaphor is not a linguistic device, but rather should be seen as a cognitive phenomenon – in this case, as a means of thinking about the concept of 'happiness' (*lykke*). The metaphor relies on the easy-to-understand concept of 'up' (op) to understand the harder-to-understand concept of 'happiness' (lykke). According to Lakoff and Johnson's second point, the metaphor has not come about by chance, but rather is grounded in an experiential correspondence between two concepts. In the case of the metaphor HAPPY IS UP, Lakoff and Johnson suggest that the metaphor is grounded in the experiential correspondence between the concept of 'happiness' and the concept of 'up': When experiencing happiness, our posture tends to be upright; conversely, our posture will often be more sunken when we are feeling sad.

How do we think about and experience play and practice?

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In light of the above, Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory can be summarised as fol-

lows: It argues that our everyday language metaphors can say something both about how we *think* about a concept and how we *experience* a concept. In the case of the metaphor HAPPY IS UP, they claim, for example, that this metaphor shows that we think of happiness as something that is 'up', and we experience happiness as associated with having an upright posture. This opens up an exciting perspective: How can we gain knowledge about play and practice? We can exploit the fact that play and practice are very common concepts in everyday language (in Danish and several other languages) to try to unravel a number of everyday language metaphors for play and practice that could potentially say something about how we both think about and experience the concepts of play and practice.

In continuation of this perspective, I will give a taste of how Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory can be used methodologically to identify the following:

- metaphorical *similarities* between play and practice that can provide insight into how they can be viewed as related.
- metaphorical *differences* between play and practice that can provide insight into how they can be viewed as different.

I do this by first describing a metaphorical similarity between play and practice, and then a metaphorical difference between play and practice.

Metaphorical similarity: play and practice as only an apparent reality

In Danish and English everyday language, we find a common metaphor for play and practice, which I formulate as PLAY AND PRACTICE IS AN APPARENT REALITY. This metaphor is reflected, among other things, in the fact that we tend to use the words 'just' (in Danish bare) or 'only' (in Danish kun) when talking about play and practice – to communicate that play and practice are not 'real life' and therefore should not be taken as seriously as the real world. For example, if you see some children fighting, you may be reassured by the words: "Bare rolig, det er bare en leg." (Don't worry, it's just a game) If you come across some dogs fighting, the dog owner can reassure you with the words: "Bare rolig, de leger bare." (Don't worry, they're just playing) If you see a lot of emergency vehicles driving by, you can be reassured by the words: "Bare rolig, det er bare en øvelse." (Don't worry, it's just a drill). And if you find yourself running out of a building because the fire alarm has gone off, you can also be reassured by the same words. In English, too, you can talk about play and practice as something that is not the same as "the real world" and should therefore not be taken as seriously. For example, you can use expressions such as "This is not a game" or "This is not a drill" when you want to appeal to someone to take something more seriously.

In the above examples, we talk about play and practice in a way that can best be described as (only) an apparent reality (in Danish *skinvirkelighed*). According to Den Danske Ordbog, the word 'skin-' (as in 'skinvirkelighed') denotes something "which in reality – on the face of it, officially – is not what it appears to be; which has no real content" (Ordnet.dk, 2024) (My translation). In the above examples, play and practice are precisely talked about as something "which in reality – on the face of it, officially – is not what it appears to be". For this reason, I use the term 'skinvirkelighed' (apparent reality) to sum up the metaphor.

Many examples can be given where it seems obvious that play and practice are not regarded as 'the real word', but rather as an apparent reality. For example, it seems obvious that a playful fight (or 'play fighting') is not a real fight, or that a military exercise is not the same as real war. In the same way, it also seems obvious that children who pretend to be doing surgery on a doll are not doing real surgery, and that medical students who are practising surgery on a manikin or in a simulator are not performing a real operation.

Metaphorical difference: play as an outward movement, practice as an inward movement

In everyday language, we also find a very interesting metaphorical difference between play and practice, which I have never seen pointed out in literature about play or practice. We get a sense of this metaphorical difference as we discover the following difference in how we understand play and practice in everyday language: We tend to understand the concept of 'play' through the spatial concept of 'out', and practice through the spatial concept of 'in'. This manifests itself in Danish everyday language by the tendency to describe play using 'out' words (words that use the Danish 'ud' or Latin *ex* as a prefix), and conversely by the tendency to describe practice using 'in' words (words that use the Danish 'ind' or Latin *in* as a prefix). For example, in Danish we tend to describe play using concepts such as 'udøve' (exercise), 'udtrykke' (express), 'udforske' (explore) and 'eksperimentere' (experiment), and practice using concepts such as 'indøve', 'indlære', 'indterpe' (all three words involve the notion of taking something in), 'internalisere' (internalise), 'inkorporere' (incorporate) and 'indoktrinere' (indoctrinate).

However, the above only describes a rough metaphorical difference between play and practice. In my thesis, based on an extensive study of the use of play and practice as concepts in everyday language as well as in play and practice theory, I derive two different everyday language play and practice metaphors. They can help us examine the question of how play and practice can be viewed as different forms of activity.

AN EVERYDAY LANGUAGE METAPHOR FOR PLAY

As regards play, I derive an everyday language metaphor for play: PLAYING IS STEPPING OUT OF SOMETHING. I divide it into three sub-metaphors, which are expressed both in everyday language and in play theory:

1. Playing is stepping out of the mind or self

- This metaphor is expressed in everyday language: The English words *exaltation*, *excitement*, *exhilaration*, *expansion*, *extravagance*, exultation and *ecstatic*, with the Latin prefix *ex*, describe or connote play, implying an understanding of play as an exit or deliverance from the mind or self. In a contemporary Danish context, the word 'selvforglemmelse' (self-forgetfulness) is often used to describe play.
- The metaphor is also expressed in play theory: Among some play theorists, we find a tendency to talk about play as something that involves *stepping out of* one's self or mind. This is expressed, for example, in a quote by the German philosopher and play theorist Eugen Fink (2016): "While playing, the human being does not remain in himself, does not remain in an enclosed domain of his psychic interiority – rather, he ecstatically *steps out of* [my italics] and beyond himself in a cosmic gesture and

interprets the world in a manner that is suffused with sense" (Fink, 2016, p. 46).

2. Playing is stepping out of normal or everyday life

- This metaphor is expressed in everyday language: The English words *exceed, excess, extreme, eccentric, exotic, exaggerate, exorbitant* and *exhibitionism*, which are all prefixed with the Latin *ex*, describe or connote play, which may imply an understanding of play as an exit from normal or everyday life.
- The metaphor is also expressed in play theory: Some play theorists tend to explicitly talk about playing as being tantamount to *stepping out of* 'the real world'. See, for example, this observation by historian and play theorist Johan Huizinga (2016) (1949): "A second characteristic is closely connected with this, namely, that play is not 'ordinary' or 'real' life. It is rather *stepping out of* [my italics] 'real' life into a temporary sphere of activity with a disposition all of its own" (Huizinga, 2016, p. 8).

3. Playing is stepping out of the familiar or well-known

- This metaphor is expressed in everyday language: The English words *excursion*, *experiment* and *explore*, with the Latin prefix *ex*, describe or connote play, which may imply an understanding of play as a stepping out of the familiar or well-known. In the same way, the very common expression 'going out to play' (in Danish 'ud at lege') suggests that play takes place outside, away from what is homely and familiar. Quite a few examples can be found in our cultural heritage of children's play being viewed as something that takes place outdoors, and how people with a more romantic view of play tend to prefer for children to play outdoors.

AN EVERYDAY LANGUAGE METAPHOR FOR PRACTICE

As regards "practice," I derive the following everyday language metaphor: PRACTICE IS TO TAKE SOMETHING IN/ABSORB SOMETHING INTO THE BODY

- This metaphor is expressed in everyday language: In Danish we tend to use 'ind' (in) words to describe practice, for example 'indøve' (rehearse), 'indlære' (take in), 'indstudere' (rehearse), 'indarbejde' (incorporate), 'internalisere' (internalise) and 'indoktrinere' (indoctrinate). Across many languages, we find the notion that knowledge or skills that you have acquired through practice are located somewhere *inside the body*. In Danish, we tend to focus on the spine or backbone, for example in expressions such as 'at få noget ind på rygraden' (make something part of your backbone). According to Den Danske Ordbog, the word 'rygrad' (backbone) can mean "a place for learned skills, routines or prejudices" (Ordnet.dk, 2024) (My translation). In other languages, like ancient Greek, Arabic and Hebrew, the heart is the seat of memory, which is also reflected in the English and French phrases for memorisation: learning by heart and *par cœur*, respectively. The Danish-German expression *udenadslære/auswendig lernen* also seems to support an understanding of what has been acquired as something that sits inside the body, as it probably originally refers to 'without a book'. To know something by heart means, in this perspective, to have an acquired practice *inside the body*. It means

that you have no need for external aids such as books, calculators, recipes, manuals etc.

- The metaphor is also expressed in play theory: Across different theories, practice is often described with 'ind' (in) words. In cognitivist theory, practice is described as the *'internalisation of mental representations'*, in body phenomenological theory as the *'incorporation of memory'*, and the Danish musician Peter Bastian (1991) described practice as *'technical and mental inlearning'* (a direct translation of the Danish word *"indlæring."*).

Two pointers for considering the relationship between play and practice

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As mentioned earlier, play and practice have become two important themes in both social and teacher education. It may thus be relevant for educators on the social and teacher education programmes to look into the relationship between play and practice. The above metaphorical similarity and metaphorical difference between play and practice can serve as pointers for educators wanting to explore the relationship between play and practice.

In order to develop an answer to the question of how we can understand play and exercise as related activity concepts, the everyday language metaphor PLAY AND PRACTICE IS AN APPARENT REALITY can serve as an important pointer. It is a pointer that can be formulated as a question: Why is it that we seem inclined to think of play and practice as being related – by not being about 'the real world', but by being only an apparent reality? With reference to Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory, and their suggestion that everyday language metaphors are grounded in experience, this pointer can also be formulated as follows: What might be the experiential basis for this metaphorical similarity between play and practice?

In order to develop answers to the question of how to understand play and practice as different activity concepts, the above metaphorical difference can also serve as an important pointer. With reference to Lakoff and Johnson's metaphor theory, this pointer can be formulated as follows: What might be the experiential basis for this metaphorical difference between play and practice? What types of experiences can explain our tendency to think of *play as a movement out of something – as a movement out of the* mind or self, everyday life or the normal or the familiar and well-known – and, conversely, our inclination to think of *practice as a movement into something*, as a process that involves absorbing something into the body?

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P3

PERSPECTIVE 3

ON MEETING IN SHARED PLAYFUL SPACES

– learning to play together in social education and teacher education

BY KIM HOLFLOD

Kim Holflod, PhD, Assistant Professor at University College Copenhagen & Postdoc, Danish School of Education, Aarhus University. This article is based on Holflod's PhD project: Legende tværprofessionelle uddannelser: Designbaserede undersøgelser af sprog og samarbejde om legende tilgange til læring. (Playful Interprofessional Education – Design-based Inquiries of Language and Collaboration in Playful Learning).

I REMEMBER FEELING NERVOUS ABOUT MEETING NEW PEOPLE
I REMEMBER FUNNY ICEBREAKERS
I REMEMBER PLAYLAB AS INSPIRING INPUT
I REMEMBER THE LACK OF WHY I DO THINGS
I REMEMBER PEOPLE'S TRUE COMMITMENT
I REMEMBER FEELING SURPRISINGLY POSITIVE ABOUT THE PROCESS
I REMEMBER STRONG AND VALUABLE COLLABORATION
I REMEMBER A LOT OF NEW TOOLS FOR COLLABORATION
I REMEMBER THE CREATIVITY AND PLAYFUL ASPECTS OF THE TEACHING
I REMEMBER INSPIRING AND PASSIONATE TEACHERS

Poetic reflections of a student on an interprofessional course on playful didactics.

In this article, I present selected results from my PhD dissertation *Legende tværprofessionelle uddannelser* (Holflod, 2023a). The dissertation is article-based, and in it I examine playful interprofessional education – and what unfolds between the teacher education and social education programmes when educators develop playful approaches to learning and create a language for it, as well as how students experience participating and learning about each other through playful and professional forms of collaboration.

I would like to explain *how playful collaboration can support and qualify students' interprofessional relationships, opportunities for participation and collaboration* – and how such collaboration is therefore a relevant perspective of topical interest in the development of interprofessional education. It is a key finding in the dissertation that playful approaches affect and qualify socialisation, participation and relationships between educational programmes. This is the result that tells us the most about how students experience engaging in playful and interprofessional forms of collaboration, and how this knowledge can be used to organise teaching activities and education.

I speak of *interprofessional education* as distinct from interprofessional practice. I would like to briefly describe the difference between the concepts. There is a difference between practitioners, for example in schools, working together to address complex issues such as inclusion or a child refusing to go to school, which they have to deal with and resolve by drawing on their own professional skills

– or whether students studying to become social educators and teachers meet during their studies to learn about their respective disciplines and professions. While practice must focus on problem-solving and making everyday life work, education can support students' development into competent and reflective interprofessional practitioners. While education is a different kind of space where learning and development are top of mind, it is also challenged by the fact that students must learn to cross several different boundaries: professional, disciplinary and educational. This means, for my work, that I am keen to investigate and experiment with ways in which playful forms of collaboration affect interprofessional education. Therefore, for now, I would like to highlight four key concepts:

Play (and playfulness)
Interprofessionalism
Boundaries
Education

In my research project, I have – together with educators – developed, tested and evaluated a large number of playful design experiments, the goals often having been to develop students' nascent understandings of their respective professions, to create a didactic space for interprofessional socialisation and to facilitate different opportunities for participation. My approach draws methodologically on design-based research – and it has been central to me that dialogue and relationality should be fundamental in both the development work undertaken together with educators and in the students' interactions and forms of participation. Perhaps it is already becoming apparent that a number of concepts and ways of thinking will give shape to my dissertation:

Relationships
Design
Participation
Dialogue

In this article, I first present a few theoretical takeaways from my dissertation. The aim is to briefly introduce central, relevant thinking and theory from the dissertation: There will be a few words about play theory and a few words about *boundaries* in interprofessional education. Then follows a presentation of practical takeaways, selected experiments and empirical voices. Dialogically, voices must be understood in a broad sense and as including thematics, discourses, values or ideologies – and not necessarily as concrete utterances in a conversation. Finally, I round off the article by suggesting how educators can plan playful interprofessional teaching and educational activities – and what it can contribute to professional bachelor's programmes.

Theoretical takeaway: playful approaches to boundaries and relational pedagogy

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In the research project, I have investigated and developed boundaries in different perspectives: (1) between research and practice, and (2) between students from the social education and teacher education programmes.

As a design-based researcher, when collaborating with educators from university colleges to develop playful educational and teaching experiments, I understand the relationship between research and practice as an epistemic partnership. As partners, we

problematise the world around us together, effectively co-creating the 'field' (Estalella & Criado, 2018). In other words, researchers are *also co-practitioners*, and practitioners are *also co-researchers*. Our partnership is thus epistemic as we investigate and create knowledge and practice together – in the hope of developing novel theories and practices.

When I talk about boundaries between students, it is to do with the fact that I learned, early on in my research, that students from different programmes both experienced and actively described the existence of multiple boundaries. In interprofessional education, the boundaries were not just disciplinary, but also professional – within and across the individual professional bachelor's programmes – and educational in the form of boundaries associated with institutional and organisational structures, logics and fields of practice. In this connection, I was inspired by *dialogic boundary crossing* as a concept to examine the different boundaries that students cross in interprofessional education – and by extension, how students, through their encounters with each other's differences, can learn about interprofessionality.

In my further work to develop teaching and educational practices with playful perspectives, an obvious focus area was ways in which students can co-create playful and aesthetic *boundary objects*. A boundary object is characterised by facilitating communication between different worlds and creating opportunities for boundary crossing, as the object is ambiguous and open to different and flexible interpretations on either side of the boundary. Boundary objects may take the form of, for example, shared field notes, drawings, maps, prototypes and the like. I later developed this into *objects-to-relate-with* as results from multiple interventions and iterations showed that the students' co-created objects not only mediated communication and reflection, but also enabled both experiential, affective and vulnerable interpersonal connections.

This is in sharp contrast to current problematisations and discourses that contemporary education is influenced by performativity, individualisation and measurability. These are trends that also affect playful learning in higher education and the inherent desire for different pedagogical strategies capable of embracing relationships, collaborations and conversations in new ways. I will return to that later.

In my dissertation, I show that playful forms of collaboration enable different participatory strategies and socialisation across professional bachelor's programmes and multiple boundaries. Such forms of collaboration can be supported and qualified by object-mediated communication and reflection as well as the construction of sensuous boundary objects – *objects-to-relate-with* – through which students can acquire different communicative and collaborative strategies for interprofessional participation. Overall, this means that in my dissertation, I unfold the potential of playful interprofessional education to double reality. Room is created for students to learn and collaborate creatively, imaginatively, soulfully and experimentally: It mediates participation among the professional bachelor's programmes and creates new relational potentials for collaboration and communication.

Practical takeaway: micro-utopias, constructions and empirical voices

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In the research project, together with educators, I have co-created, tested, evaluated and iterated various teaching and educational activities centring around playful forms of collaboration. This has resulted in versatile experiments with playful approaches to collaboration and teaching. Below, I present and unfold, in particular, *micro-utopias* as a design experiment framed by collaborative design and construction. We have also tested various playful forms of collaboration and learning processes based on physicality, roles, imagination and performativity, but since the specific focus of the dissertation is to examine students' experiences of playful collaborations associated with their shared constructions, this is the perspective unfolded in the following.

Play comes in multiple forms, including construction play, role play, imaginative play, bodily play, social play and creative play. As we begin to imagine and develop playful educational scenarios, we project elements of play – such as characteristics or qualities of play – into activities that are not necessarily play (Sicart, 2014). So, we are no longer talking about the phenomenon of play, but rather about taking a playful approach or having a playful attitude to the world, which can be expressed in, for example, social, creative and aesthetic learning processes and forms of collaboration. In quite a few experiments, we have in the development and testing of playful interprofessional educational practices, taken as our starting point various forms of construction play as social, relational and creative events. From there, we have facilitated the exploration and discussion by students of academic issues and perspectives together – using materials and spaces. Constructions (e.g. visualisations and modelling) are important here.

The theoretical starting point of my project was that in situations where collaboration across diverse boundaries and fields of practice is challenging, co-created objects can serve as mediating boundary objects and catalysts for the creation of alternative relational connections. It is in this context that I want to take a practical look at the co-creation of micro-utopias. In this activity, students have collaborated across professional bachelor's programmes to visualise and create – using mixed materials and through spatial involvement – desirable and conceivable futures for our practices, institutions and society. Inspired by speculative design, utopian thinking and play theory, the aim of the activity is to produce, investigate and unfold diverse perspectives – and, in other words, to create a dialogic space with multiple different disciplinary, professional, experience-based, sensory and affective voices. The goal is not to build or be able to realise a utopian vision; rather, it is to think and engage in utopian and playful processes that can pave the way for new forms of collective thinking, dialogue, boundary crossing and multiplicity:

The idea of utopia is far more interesting when used as a stimulus to keep idealism alive, not as something to try to make real but as a reminder of the possibility of alternatives, as somewhere to aim for rather than build (73) [...] *Micro-utopias like these serve as inspiration, encouraging not mega-utopias defined from the top down, but seven billion little utopias emerging from the bottom up* (Dunne & Raby, 2013ps. 164).

In the activity, the student social educators and student teachers create an interpro-

fessional take on what the playful school of the future may look like when they dream together – when they collaborate exploratively, creatively and playfully about what they desire and not just what should be or what is. What matters is not whether the students succeed in creating a finished product together, but whether their symbolic and playful narratives can mediate and qualify their collaboration.

Based on near-empirical analyses of observations, interviews, reflection texts, field notes and reflection workshops, my dissertation demonstrates that something special happens when students engage in playful social interactions. As regards interprofessional education, they experience – and emphasise – that they must learn to navigate a multitude of boundaries: disciplinary, professional, educational and social. It is challenging when they not only have to reflect on their own emerging professional and disciplinary identity, but also have to navigate ways of bringing it into play in relation to others – as well as everything that others bring to the collaboration and relationship.

When reflecting on activities and processes involving playful forms of collaboration, students describe, among other things, an experience of accelerated socialisation and acquisition of alternative strategies of participation. In the words of the students, alternative and novel communicative and collaborative spaces are created that both facilitate and advance incipient interprofessional relationships and understandings. Through creating and building things together and working with materials and each other, a starting point is created for mediating dialogue and interaction. Engaging in different and demanding relations feels a little safer and less vulnerable when they can project something of themselves into objects.

That is the first point: In interprofessional educational settings, playful interactions with constructions can enable the creation of a meaningful both affective and professional space for collaboration. By allowing themselves to dream loud and wild, they create opportunities for listening to each other's different professional voices – but also all sorts of other voices coming from different disciplinary, professional, conceptual and practical starting points.

The objects enable multiplicity, and what I have called generative co-creation between discursive and symbolic dialogue, which is not only conducive to professional problem understandings and problem solving, but also creates a different starting point for relational connections (Holflod, 2023). That is the second point – and let us try to highlight some perspectives again:

Construction play
Playful approaches
Micro-utopias
Socialisation
Relationships

On professional bachelor's programmes, we are currently seeing – and arguably have also seen historically – politicised and sometimes polarised discussions: about professional bachelor's programmes being poised between academisation and skills-based education, between theory and practice. At the same time, education systems – and especially higher education – are both nationally and internationally affected by performative and streamlining trends, by measurability, instrumentalisation and control, while professional

bachelor's programmes are challenged specifically by increased drop-out rates and falling student numbers.

The point I want to make is not that playful approaches to learning and education is the solution to every problem. But playful approaches can – and must? – play a role in how we didactically, pedagogically and structurally think, talk about and organise interprofessional educational programmes, and possibly also how we plan education more broadly.

The results from my dissertation provide a glimpse of what is possible when teaching and education begin to revolve around processes, relationships, exploration and experimentation – focusing less on instruction, efficiency and individuals. As a developing field of research and practice, playful higher education provides opportunities to think, talk about and make professional education different – and transform value-based, didactic, pedagogical and institutional discussions, frameworks and processes.

In my dissertation, I develop the contours of relational pedagogy as a soulful affair. This is done through research into and the development of playful interprofessional education as paradoxical and tensional between control and uncontrollability, structures and anti-structures, as well as commonality and diversity. And it is precisely through playful relationships and forms of collaboration that the shared space can be enabled by:

Soulfulness
Paradoxicality
Pedagogy

A soulful affair – playing with boundaries and participation

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In this article, I explain what students experience when engaging in playful forms of collaboration across educational programmes: That such collaboration can provide opportunities for alternative and qualified participation, socialisation and collaboration, for students coming together in deeply relational spaces. The students participating in the experiments talk about connecting through playful forms of collaboration, through the playful transformation of their participation, of boundaries and relationships. Collectively opening up to each other and forming common notions of professions, being, becoming, belonging and the future introduces an interpersonal sense of responsibility between the participating educators and students.

This, I point out, qualifies interprofessional education – but at the same time approaching teaching and education critically and reflectively also becomes an ethical imperative. In the last section of this article, I will therefore highlight two dimensions that have been touched upon so far: (1) soulfulness in pedagogy and education, and (2) possible contributions to professional bachelor's programmes in particular and educational institutions in general.

What does being soulful mean? And what does it mean in the context of interprofessional education – or just pedagogy and education? In my dissertation and several related articles, I have, inspired by the phenomenologist Les Todres, described soulful pedagogy and soulful education as open-ended, uncertain and potentially vulnerable connections between participants that create opportunities for deep relationships and qualified

socialisation processes. Todres specifically describes soulful spaces – and how vulnerability can be seen as providing a foundation for empathic connections with others (Todres, 2007). This was the direct inspiration for the exploration in my dissertation of how care and relationships are mediated and supported by playful collaborations and processes – and how this can create opportunities for different and stronger interprofessional relationships between educational programmes and interprofessional programmes.

It is an important point in the dissertation that such relationships qualify opportunities for participation and transgress professional, disciplinary and educational boundaries. At a time where professional bachelor's programmes and higher education are increasingly dominated by instrumentalisation and performativity, and where this not only affects student participation and teaching, but also more fundamentally shapes who we as educators and students are and become (Ball, 2003), a soulful perspective becomes not only theoretically interesting, but also practically relevant.

However, the positioning of relationality and participation as an ethical imperative remains a point of attention. That is, the insistence that education must be in a certain way, characterised especially by collaboration, participation, relationships and sociality. That is not the point here. In the dissertation and its articles, I argue that multiplicity, diversity and polyphony are essential. Therefore, I do not try to operationalise or reduce an education philosophy to a simple – soulful – perspective inspired by playful relationships. But my investigations offer both theoretical and empirical contributions to the development of concepts that may aid how we think and talk about pedagogy and education, and how we go about it.

Finally, I will recap the article and present my ideas for ways in which we can think about and practise playful interprofessional teaching and education. In the dissertation, I position the results of my research project as a specific contribution to professional bachelor's programmes – especially the social education and teacher education programmes. It is also a broader and more general contribution to other institutions of higher education that work with interprofessional study relationships and forms of education and which are equally concerned with participation, professionalism, relations and connections between them. In this article, I present selected results from my PhD dissertation on playful interprofessional education (Holflod, 2023a).

Three important points from the text:

1. It is crucial to distinguish between interprofessional education and interprofessional practice. While education focuses on advancing students' personal and professional development, in practice, collaboration is centred on resolving concrete challenges and day-to-day operations. At the same time, interprofessional education is affected by a complexity of boundaries that students must deal with and navigate. This calls for alternative and innovative pedagogy and didactics in the education sector.
2. Playful forms of collaboration affect socialisation, participation and the establishment of relationships between students across different educational programmes. In playful processes, opportunities are developed for alternative strategies for participation

and socialisations across different professional bachelor's programmes, and overcoming the barriers existing between them.

3. Interprofessional education – with a playful, relational and soulful overtone – can be investigated and enabled through objects as mediating tools. Here, construction and materialisation in co-creative processes become the starting point for new communicative and relational opportunities in teaching and education.

The highlighted points illustrate the importance of playful approaches in interprofessional education and how they can unfold and improve student participation, socialisation, collaboration and relationships across different educational specialisations. In this article, I have disseminated selected knowledge from a longer PhD dissertation, which also frames and discusses problem areas, the perspectives of educators, methodological and theoretical dimensions, as well as connections between knowledge, design processes and ethics. Finally, there are several aspects and problems associated with playful interprofessional and higher education that have not been illuminated, investigated or discussed either here or in my PhD thesis. So, as this article ends, I would like to stress that there is still much to talk about regarding the development and qualification of playful higher education.

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P4

SEVEN PRINCIPLES FOR IMPLEMENTING PLAYFUL APPROACHES TO LEARNING

BY VICI DAPHNE HÄNDEL

Vici Daphne Händel, Associate Professor and PhD at University College Copenhagen. This article is based on Händel's PhD project: Reformulating the institutionalised role of student teachers through playful approaches to learning: A design-based research study of student teachers' embodied, playful presence in learning situations.

Imagine a learning situation at an institution of higher education where the mood and the atmosphere are truly playful. The educator is being playful, facilitating playful learning processes. Even the classroom has been transformed into a play lab designed to invite, inspire and insist on playful approaches to learning. Imagine dedicated students playfully engaged in the learning activities. Laughter and joyfulness driving academic progress. Imagine the students' preoccupation with the playful learning process, which will give them the knowledge, skills and competencies that they will need in their future careers as primary and lower secondary school teachers (Händel, 2024).

In this article, I am introducing seven design principles for playful learning, which I developed in my PhD project *Reformulating the institutionalised role of student teachers through playful approaches to learning: A design-based research study of student teachers' embodied, playful presence in learning situations*. In the project, I have focused on:

1. how playful approaches to learning, framed by physical activity and technology-integrated activities, challenge the institutionalised role of student teachers
2. how the activities contribute to the student teachers' embodied, playful presence in learning situations
3. and how to realise playful approaches to learning in teacher education (Händel et al., 2024).

Towards a changed teaching culture

In recent years, there has been a focus in higher education on challenging teaching methods associated with students being passive and inactive (Händel et al., 2023). Since 2018, the six university colleges in Denmark have been working with playful approaches to learning as part of a major national programme – Playful Learning. One of the aims is to implement teaching methods characterised by students being more active and creative. The implementation of playful approaches to learning must be based on pedagogical and didactic considerations. Didactics and design principles are closely linked, yet focus on different aspects of teaching. Design principles are about the ways we structure, plan and organise learning experiences. Didactics is the study of teaching and learning, and focuses on how to organise the content, purpose, methods and evaluation of the teaching.

For my study on the teacher education programmes, more specifically the 'Technology Comprehension and Digital Bildung' module, I used a design-based research approach (Christensen et al., 2012). As part of this research approach, I have worked with design principles. Design principles can serve

as guidelines for creating and developing a teaching environment where students can experiment, explore and learn through fun and creative activities, fostering engagement and a deeper understanding of a given topic. Design principles can create and promote engaging learning activities characterised by an embodied, playful presence among the students.

An embodied, playful presence should be understood as *the students' physical and emotional attitude and their stance towards the learning activities, which appears as the mood and atmosphere in specific moments depicted in the current dynamics and interactions of the activity* (Händel, 2024).

The design principles have been developed for use on teacher education programmes, but the principles can be used in the teaching of other subjects, on other degree programmes and by other stakeholders who want to challenge traditional learning designs through playful approaches to learning.

Students encounter an unfamiliar and unknown teaching strategy

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Imagine that you are a student teacher. You are on your way to class. As a student, you have acquired specific institutional habits to do with the teaching methods practised, the layout and interior design of the classroom, the content of lessons and so on. You know your own role and position in the learning environment. Both physically and cognitively, you have become entangled in the existing educational tradition and culture. Now imagine all this being challenged (Händel, 2024).

My research shows, among other things, that the implementation of playful approaches to learning challenges the institutionalised role of students and their agency. This is evident, among other things, in the students' different attitudes and stances towards learning activities characterised by an embodied and playful presence, in the form of resistance, curiosity and nonengagement. My research also shows that students are affected by situational constraints when exposed to playful teaching strategies. The constraints can have to do with new teaching strategies as well as the teaching of new subjects, social interactions among the students and the changed teaching culture (Händel, 2023). In many ways, the students are coming face to face with a form of teaching they have not previously been used to.

As an educator, you can encounter many challenges when implementing playful approaches to learning in your teaching. In this situation, design principles can be helpful. Because through the development, implementation and work with design principles, we develop a keener focus on supporting creative and playful learning processes. We start focusing on the students' embodied, playful presence and on motivating students to actively participate and to increase their engagement.

Of course, it is important to mention that my research also shows that you cannot coerce or force students into being embodied and playful; but as an educator, with the help of design principles, you can facilitate learning activities from which playful moods or atmospheres can emerge (Händel, 2024). On the teacher education programmes, the introduction of the PhD project's seven design principles and playful learning approaches has proven to be a promising strategy for promoting an embodied, playful presence.

Seven design principles

The design principles I have developed focus on how student teachers can gain the competences, knowledge and skills needed to enact playful learning, physical activity and technology-integrated activities in their future role as primary and lower secondary school teachers. The principles were also designed to inspire educators to facilitate and enact them in practice.

The educator must organise learning activities that enable the student teachers' embodied, playful presence, offering them the opportunity to experiment, follow their own learning paths and be brave, curious, imaginative, creative and engaged in the playful learning process. However, the playful approach to learning must be integrated into pedagogical didactics ensuring a safe and meaningful practice. This must be done in a way where traditional roles and situational constraints no longer act as barriers to the student teachers' playful participation in the learning activities. You can read about the development of the design principles later in the article. First, I will present the seven principles and how they have been reflected in my research.

Principle 1:
Creating a playful learning space for imagining together using digital tools

The first design principle is about using digital technologies as didactic co-players in teaching situations. Relevant digital technologies could be micro:bits, Blue-Bots, tablets or Ozo bots. As didactic co-players, the digital technologies must help support the students' reflection and learning.

The purpose of this design principle was to provide students with knowledge of various digital technologies, their affordances as well as of simple programming and computational thinking. The students had to ask questions, reflect and experiment with different digital technologies through iterative processes. As an educator, I facilitated a digital creative workshop with the digital technologies playing the role of didactic co-players. As an educator, I also had to facilitate a process to ensure that the students were ready to participate – using the materials as didactic co-players – with an embodied, playful presence, while being curious and creative.

I found that the students had no prior knowledge of any of the digital technologies that I made available to them in class. Therefore, I started by encouraging the students to explore the different digital technologies and their affordances in groups. Later on and using the digital technologies, the students were asked to create what is known in Denmark as a Storm P machine (in the UK as a Heath Robinson contraption and in the US as a Rube Goldberg machine), a complex construction designed to solve a simple task, often in a humorous and excessively elaborate way.

The aim of the lesson was for the students, with the help of their overcomplicated Storm P. machines, to learn about simple programming, but also to learn – in a playful way – about computational thinking, the purpose being to train their ability to solve complex problems in a simple way. All the time with the digital technologies as didactic co-players.

Principle 2:
Creating a playful learning space where students and educators dare to go for unpredictability

According to the second design principle, the educator must create a teaching situa-

tion with time and space for the students to participate in unpredictable and open-ended learning processes. Although educators may have planned a teaching activity both pedagogically and didactically, they must allow for unpredictable learning processes. This means that the students are given the chance to pursue their own learning processes and remain engaged for longer in open-ended and creative teaching processes, leading to new opportunities for learning and surprising reflections.

My study showed that many students are focused on reaching the learning goal as quickly as possible. The students would ask me how to best solve the task, whether the task had been solved in the right way, and be keen to adhere to a specific learning process rather than testing multiple options and solutions (Händel, 20204). By spending more time on the playful learning process, students can find the courage to pursue their own ideas and be brave enough to engage in unpredictable processes. It is in the unpredictable processes that new opportunities for learning and surprising reflections can arise.

Principle 3:
Creating a playful meaningful learning space

According to the third design principle, playful learning processes must be integrated into the learning process in ways that are meaningful for both the educator and the students. Students often ask about the educator's didactic considerations. They ask the basic questions such as: who, what, where, when, how and why. As an example of this, in the pilot project I came across a student who kept asking why the students should be taught about playful approaches to learning and about technology comprehension. The student said that playful approaches to learning and technology comprehension would not be of any use to them, giving the following reason: "I'm going to be a Danish teacher."

As an educator, it was my job to make sure that the teaching was perceived by the student as being meaningful. It is important to emphasise that playful approaches to learning must be adapted so that they support the students in their learning and understanding of the curriculum, and that the level of playfulness must be adapted to the level of the participants. In other words, my study was about making the playful approaches, technology comprehension and digital literacy useful for the students in teaching situations in, for example, primary and lower secondary school. At the same time, it was about showing how playful approaches to learning can be a way to vary one's teaching methods – not only in higher education, but also in primary and lower secondary schools.

Principle 4:
Creating a playful and safe learning space to ensure the notion of failability

According to the fourth design principle, the educator must facilitate a learning environment where students feel safe enough to dare make mistakes. A relationship characterised by mutual trust and engagement must be created between the students and the educator. The students must learn that failability is also a path to learning. Playful approaches to learning can involve making mistakes as part of the learning process. The students must embrace and accept making mistakes with an open mind and understand that the learning process may contain a risk of making mistakes along the way.

At the same time, the educator can facilitate a teaching situation where failing and making mistakes is a meaningful part of the teachingactivity. Daring to fail and failability can help students spend more time in the learning process, thereby creating more learning opportunities. Students learn to analyse their actions, understand problems better and find alternative solutions. In this way, students acquire the skills needed to solve problems.

Principle 5:
Creating a playful learning space that encourages an experimental practice

The fifth design principle is about the facilitation by the educator of learning processes that ensure that students feel safe enough in the learning space to enter into and engage in practical, experimental learning activities. It is assumed that student teachers can achieve the intended learning outcomes by participating in experimental teaching practices. This means that the pedagogical and didactic planning of the activity ensures a link between the subject's theory, method and practice.

In my study, it became clear that when students started lacking in energy, it helped to take the learning activity in a new and experimenting direction to bring about a renewed embodied, playful presence among the students. I also found that the students' state of embodied, playful presence lasted for longer when engaged in teaching activities with several different experimental elements.

Principle 6:
Creating space for renegotiation of the learners' role, position and teaching method

The sixth design principle is about both the educator and the students being able to negotiate new roles, positions and teaching methods together in playful approaches to learning.

The design principle is about the students experiencing lessons where the educator does not always know everything and does not always have all the solutions and answers. For the students to achieve a state of embodied, playful presence, they must engage actively with the themes, topics and theories of the subject being taught. Students must be co-creators of the pedagogical and didactic thinking about what teaching can be, and they must explore different roles and positions.

Principle 7:
Creating a playful learning space that encourages physical activity

The seventh and final design principle is based on the fact that national and international research shows that physical activity and exercise before, during and just after a teaching activity can support students' learning, well-being and health. Physical activity covers a wide range of movement. In this design principle, the focus is on gross motor movement patterns such as running, jumping, hopscotching etc. Physical activity can be facilitated by the educator as an integral part of the curriculum, but can also be initiated by the students as an active way of engaging in a learning activity.

The educator therefore organises the teaching so that there is time and space for physical activity as part of the learning process. My study showed that physical activity must be meaningful and integrated into the teaching activity as students otherwise choose to do the task without being physically active. As an important part of playful teach-

ing, physical activity can be a joyful experience for students, creating renewed energy and motivation.

Development of my design principles

I initially did a pilot project to identify the innovation potential for playful approaches to learning on the teacher education programmes (Christensen et al., 2020). I did this based on Playful Learning's three principles: C*reate Shared Ideas, Dare the Unpredictable and Insist on Meaningfulness*. They were prepared by 36 educators from the social education and teacher education programmes taking part in Playful Learning's development project (Lyager et al., 2020).

The three principles were not conceived as static principles, but were designed so that educators on the social education and teacher education programmes could qualify, expand or rethink them and, through new test actions and didactic reflections, further develop and adapt them to specific learning contexts (Lyager, 2020). I therefore adapted the three principles to suit my study and tested them in the pilot project (Händel, 2024). The pilot project analysis showed that additional design principles were needed to create a playful approach to learning and teaching situations characterised by the embodied, playful presence of students. I therefor developed two design principles to guide my work with and ensure failability in the teaching situation, as well as a design principle based on the idea of students learning through experimental practices (Händel, 2024).

These design principles were tested in the first iteration of the PhD project, and the analysis identified a need for an additional two design principles to be implemented. These design principles focused on ensuring that roles, positions and teaching methods could be negotiated, and one design principle aimed to ensure that the students were physically active in the teaching situation.

The first three of my design principles were inspired by van den Akker's heuristics (van den Akker, 1999). Subsequently, my design principles were further refined and reformulated according to Hanghøj et al.'s model, which sheds light on ways that design principles can be formulated, introduced and assessed (Hanghøj et al., 2022).

Final thoughts

When intending to create a learning environment that challenges predetermined teaching methods and the institutionalised roles of students, educators should design principles that answer the questions of why, who, what, when and how, and what criteria should be used to articulate, implement and evaluate these principles. At the same time, educators should consider the agency of the students and the educators themselves as well as their understanding of the key factors that either enable or constrain the students' playful presence. The design principles should serve as a framework for both the educators' and the students' engagement in the learning process, while pedagogical and didactic reflections should take into account the students' prerequisites for participating in the activities.

In the pilot project, iterative processes were used, with one pilot project and two subsequent iterations being carried out to test, improve and refine the design principles in practice (Händel, 2024). The aim was to make the developed designs sufficiently robust to be used in different contexts (Christensen et

al., 2012). Each iteration involved new teaching sessions with different student teachers, and the design principles proved robust enough to be tested and applied in these contexts (Händel, 2024).

Finally, I would urge anyone wanting to implement a playful approach to teaching and learning to apply the above seven design principles. The principles can be applied as they appear at the time of writing, but they are in no way static and can be qualified, expanded or rethought through didactic and pedagogical planning practices.

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P6

IT'S FUN PLAYING THIS GRUMPY DAD

BY MARTHA LAGONI & SIGNE TONSBERG

Martha Lagoni, PhD student and associate professor at UCL University College, and Signe Tonsberg, journalist at Tonsberg Tekst. This article is based on Lagoni's PhD project: "Som om..." og "hvad nu hvis..." (As if... and what if...)

When student social educators play with roles and do small, improvised dilemma-filled plays in the classroom, they train important competences that they will need in their future roles as social educators. Martha Lagoni's PhD project links dramaturgy, play and teaching.

Scene 1

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Dad Bo is picking up his son Henrik from kindergarten. In the fictional playground, he is greeted with a big smile by Line, a student social educator doing a six-month internship in the kindergarten.

"Hi Bo", says the student who plays Line, in a bright and welcoming voice. "Henrik is right over here in the playhouse and ..."

The student playing dad Bo does not answer; he just turns around and strides towards the playhouse.

Scene 2

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Line follows father and son into the cloakroom and helps them pack up.

"Know what, Bo...", tries Line.

Bo again turns around abruptly and drags his son out of the kindergarten without saying goodbye.

Scene 3

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The next morning, the kindergarten's experienced social educator Anja approaches Bo and asks him about the incident from the day before. Bo crosses his arms and says angrily:

"I don't see any reason to talk to her. She's just an intern, so of course I'm more interested in talking to you and the other social educators (...) She's only here for six months!"

The social educator tries: "Would you mind if ... "

"No", Bo interrupts and shakes his head.

" ... we just ..." Anja tries again before she is interrupted by another "No!" and sees Bo turn around and leave the fictional kindergarten.

This is what such encounters may look and sound like when student social educators enact short, partly improvised, dilemma-filled plays in the classroom based on their own experiences from practice, for example about parental cooperation. The situation shows the core of the practice that unfolds in my PhD project: *"Som om..."* and *"hvad nu hvis..."*. In my project, I examine playful, dramaturgical approaches to teaching on the social education programmes in close interaction with the educators. My research shows that playful approaches and working with role playing can create a space where students can explore and test their professional abilities together with the educator.

Roles enable you to see the world through the eyes of others

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In close collaboration with educators on UCL University College's social education programme, I have developed a number of educational designs in the school-leisure and daycare institutions specialisation modules, covering such different themes as 'gender, body and sexuality', 'culture, ethnicity and identity' and 'parental cooperation'.

All the educational designs draw on dramaturgical expertise, i.e. the knowledge and practices behind the creative processes in theatrical productions. In short, this means that, in the classroom, the students enact scenarios and play roles related to pedagogical practices. The role plays may – as in the examples from the introduction – be based on the students' own experiences and stories from practice. It may also be that the educator and I present professional dilemmas, cases, specific framings, scenarios or roles for the students to work with.

The fundamental idea is that – by drawing on dramaturgical thinking and techniques and playing with roles – the students are able to see the world and their own current and future pedagogical practices through different eyes. Because something happens when you have to enact the role of, for example, a parent, a child, a colleague or a manager and explore the different types of inner motivation associated with each of these roles.

Playing with roles and small improvised plays in the classroom is a way to embrace play. But it is also a form of teaching that requires practice on the part of both the participating students and the facilitating educators. I will return to this below. My PhD project revolves around developing and testing didactic designs and building competences in students and educators. And it is clear that students and educators benefit from repeating these activities and gradually become more confident with this approach.

What drives the experienced social educator?

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If we, as educators, simply ask the students to play a role, it is like giving someone a guitar and saying "play!", without teaching them any grip techniques. Therefore, it is also part of all educational designs that the students are first given a brief introduction to what it is to play a role. The idea of using improvised role plays in the classroom is that the students should act a part but without acting. In other words, they play a role without deliberately changing their bodies and voices.

For this purpose, I draw on acting techniques inspired by the Russian director, actor and theatre practitioner Konstantin Stanislavski and his work with "what if…" – the so-called Magic If (Stanislavski, 2013). This means that the students create their roles by working with the *inner motivation* of the roles. Because when you identify the inner motivation of a character, it becomes easier to step into a role and understand the character's situation and dilemmas. What do I feel, and what drives me as a father in this situation? Or as an experienced educator or head of institution? Am I angry, aggrieved, upset or perhaps worried about the budgets? When the students feel what is at stake for the character they are going to play, it becomes easier to play the role.

My research shows that the work of identifying the inner motivation helps the students empathise with the characters and also boosts their self-confidence – not only in relation to playing the roles: It also gives them the courage to play with the roles – and play with pedagogical values, attitudes and norms through the roles.

The protagonist, the antagonist and the conflict

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In order to make it easier for the educators to orchestrate the processes and the improvised role plays, along the way and as part of my research I developed Spil-Skaberiet (a play generator). I call it a poetic tool. It is a simple tool that graphically presents the process and supports the students in creating a dilemma-filled, partly improvised play with clear roles, ensuring the necessary dynamics.

The role plays may be based on a case presented by the educator or on the students' own stories from practice. The essential idea is that, through the scenarios that the students invent and their role playing, they get to explore a professional dilemma from different perspectives. To make it more manageable for the students to create a compressed story line, I have developed a model together with the educators that we call the Hollywood Model. The model basically involves creating a story in *four scenes*, each with its own function:

1. The characters enter the stage. The problem and conflict are outlined.
2. The problems grow, and the conflict become clear.
3. The conflict deteriorates. Perhaps there is an attempt at a solution which makes everything worse.
4. The role play ends in the middle of a climax. This may be with a key statement or an outburst.

The second part of Spil-Skaberiet is a series of role cards designed to support the students in creating credible roles. Because this is not an exercise in playing heroes and villains, but in creating roles with opposing intentions. Therefore, we have created *four different basic roles* for the students:

5. The *protagonist* is the person who suffers, who is misunderstood, who has a problem or who sees the problem and tries to change their reality and solve the problem.
6. The *antagonist* is the person who is unfair or exercises power – and who, despite having the best of intentions, ends up creating a problem due to their ignorance or to misunderstandings.
7. The *empathiser* is the person or persons who express sympathy, compassion or understanding, but fail to do anything.
8. The *witness* is the person or persons who see the problem and the conflict, but fail to do anything about it.

The magic of the open ending

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The situation recounted in the introduction is taken from a class of student social educators from the 'pedagogy in early childhood education' specialisation working with parental cooperation. On this particular day, the plays were inspired by the challenging situations and dilemmas with parental cooperation which the students had themselves experienced in practice.

In the specific module, the educator and I introduced the students to the day's exercises. I gave a brief introduction on how to create a role based on the character's inner

motivation. The students were then given a few minutes to share an experience – a challenging situation involving parental cooperation.

They were then asked to create a three-minute play with an open ending and featuring the four basic roles: the protagonist, the antagonist, the empathiser and the witness. It is very important that the play has an open ending and that the conflict remains unresolved, because that then becomes the starting point for the professional dialogues.

The students – facilitated by the educator – then go on to explore possible endings and possible futures. These reflections are a key element in the process. After all, as students and future social educators, the students are headed for formative roles as practitioners navigating in a field without universal solutions. In their working lives, they will be creating everyday lives for and with children, where they must constantly be able to imagine many different solutions, have an eye for the details of conflict situations and always be exploring – also in relation to their own preconceptions. And this is exactly one of the things that we can train and develop together by working with roles and role playing in the classroom.

Students also have feedback roles

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And now to an important detail. When the groups perform their improvised plays, their audience of fellow students are not just conventional spectators. They are also assigned roles and instructed in how to be *spectactors*– i.e. audience members who are themselves enacting a specific role. They are thus also actors. This technique is inspired by Brazilian director and theatre practitioner Augusto Boal (Boal, 2000). This means that – before the group performs their dilemma play – the educator assigns to the fellow students different roles and thus perspectives from which they must watch the play. For example, one person is assigned the role of the head of the institution and must see the dilemma through the eyes of a manager, another must adopt the perspective of an experienced colleague, a third must see the problem as a concerned parent, and a fourth may play the child we do not see in the role play, but who is affected by the tone and the way the adults talk to each other.

The difference between being an ordinary audience member and a spectactor is that your perspective automatically changes. So when the students in the audience are subsequently asked to discuss the dilemma, they become more engaged in the dilemma and the conflict and focus on the 'ball' and not the 'man'. They provide their fellow students with feedback on their ability to perform. This also ensures that everyone in the classroom is involved and has an assignment. There are no passive members of the audience.

Because the plays end in the middle of the conflict, with an open ending, the educator and I can facilitate a professional discussion and ask our spectactors – in their roles – to share their thoughts, professional reflections and alternative solutions or suggestions for possible outcomes that were not part of the play.

In several instances, we were able to improvise a new play as a supplement to the first one, based on input from our spectactors. An example of this was a spectactor who, in the role as school principal, expressed concern about the reputation of the school. Other spectactors who had roles as parents just wanted the best possible solution for

their own child. This, in turn, provoked the spectactors who had the roles of social educators and teachers who felt compelled to insist that this was not about individual children, but about the whole group of children. All these exchanges of opinions among the spectactors became a whole dilemma play in itself and provided new perspectives on the concepts and theories involved. And the educator was able to ask the participants about their thoughts about their roles, and why they said what they did.

Here it is important to stress that the students, after enacting their roles, are always invited to contribute their own reflections as themselves. In this way, they get the opportunity to reflect on and distance themselves from the views expressed by their role, which they may not agree with themselves.

More reflective social educators through role play

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Role play and playful approaches to roles can thus help create reflective social educators. As a student social educator, by enacting a role and thus finding yourself having to imagine that the world may look different to others than it does to you, you are able to develop in-depth empathetic competences. Being able to see – and play with seeing – the world from many different perspectives is not an inherent ability. But it is a skill we can develop. The dialogues and story lines of the plays are far from always nice. The tone is often rude, cheeky and teasing. But these are all ingredients on the formative path towards becoming a social educator and ECEC professional.

In my interviews with the students, they say that they experience it as playing and stepping into another world. They are transported to a place where they allow themselves to experiment and try out new things. They turn reality upside down a bit, and it also becomes a space where they turn theoretical perspectives and academic concepts on their head. It all gets a bit wacky and quirky. But being able to play with the academic concepts and make fun of them is also a sign that you basically have a grip. So when, for example, students overplay a character or turn certain academic points upside down, it really also shows that they have an in-depth academic understanding.

Many students say that they cannot act, but, at the same time, I can see them spontaneously taking on roles and improvising. They say that they think it is fun to play a different role to their normal selves, such as the role of a grumpy dad. The student who played the dad Bo in the scenes that introduced this article said to me: "Having to play the complete opposite of myself, I thought it was fun (...) I mean, I think it's fun to play this grumpy dad."

And that is precisely what it is all about: Daring to pretend "as if" and go along with the idea of "what if..."

Interaction is important

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As Playful Learning researchers, part of our DNA is that our research is about creating. All the educational designs and sessions have been created in close interaction between the educators on the social education programme and me. It always starts with me asking the educator: "What is the most important thing the students should learn?" This is a parallel to what researcher and dramaturge Anna-Lena Østern calls the first dramaturgical question: "What story do we want to tell?" (Østern, 2021).

The educator and I jointly decide on the framing of the session. But the finished educational design is created in the classroom with the students and the educator as co-designers. Because we cannot prepare in advance what the students specifically invent, how they play their roles, and what academic perspectives the situations and roles bring up.

Likewise, the educator plays a key role as facilitator, framing and supporting the process and creating space for reflection, for example by asking questions along the way. A crucial point is that the educator must *join in the play* to get the students to speak through their roles.

What does the working method require of the educators?

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1. They must have knowledge of dramaturgical models for composition of the teaching as a whole and of basic techniques such as role creation.
2. They must invest themselves in the role of facilitator. This includes using what you are already good at. For example, some are good at group interviews and can draw on question techniques from this, while others are excellent at structuring things. These are both competences that you can draw on as a facilitator.
3. They must dare to clearly frame and steer the process, but also to seize the moment and take an open, playful and improvised approach to what happens in the classroom.

As an educator, you should know that the students are not only *enacting* a role. They are *playing* with the roles, and it is basically the same thing that children do in role play.

When you play a parent attending a parents' meeting, there are not just four ways of doing it. There are many. As an educator, you must therefore set aside your own ideas about the role and let the students explore the situation. In this way, we take the qualities of play seriously and celebrate the value of play instead of sucking it dry. Because play is also a place where students can explore their room for manoeuvre as well as the ethical, relational and value-based choices they will face as future social educators. And, in this context, the students must be allowed to push things to the limit, because sometimes it is, in fact, through our slightly transgressive, black, grotesque and playful practices that our own professional identity crystallises.

When the role can do something the student cannot yet do

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My research shows that students approach their roles very differently. Some are very active, while others are drawn towards more low-key characters. And we need the whole spectrum. During the project, I have told the students that we cannot do plays where everyone is talking. This is important, because there is a need for students to be able to participate in different ways. Some few students do not like role playing at all. After a class, one student said that she felt uncomfortable saying something in her role because she could not answer as herself. On the other hand, she could see the value of watching others playing roles and listening to the perspectives of the other roles.

As part of the 'Gender, Body and Sexuality' module, we worked with body and gender and with quite a lot of images of very different naked bodies. One of the students felt very

uncomfortable about this, and she said that she almost could not participate. But when she had to play the role of an experienced social educator and internship supervisor at a school, she was able – by taking on the role – to actually engage actively. Through her role, she was able to listen and participate in the activity. This is one of many examples from my research which show that enacting a role can also open up new perspectives for the students.

Access to another world

Taking on a role, the students are able to play in a way that they cannot quite do as themselves. It is an opportunity for them and a chance to enter another world. This is what play and the creative processes in the theatre have in common: There is the real world – and there is this other world. And when we allow cracks to open between the two, the students develop a meta-reflexivity about the professional identities that they are developing; about the world the will be working in; and about the subject matter with which they are working.

Several students say that coming face to face with the otherness of the role forces them to decide who they are and what they think themselves. In this way, working with the role leads to self-reflection and self-awareness: Because in order to be able to turn the role into a different social educator to myself, I need to reflect on what kind of social educator I am and want to be.

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Further reading

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Playing with roles – an example of a teaching session

Work questions: How can we support students in exploring their own pedagogical practice? And how can we engage the students in actively adopting the perspectives of the parents, colleagues and children?					
	TIME	ACTIVITY	PURPOSE	DRAMATURGICAL TECHNIQUE	MATERIALS
1	15 mins.	Intro and warm-up play	Framing the day + physical, and social interacting	None (instructed game)	None
2	15 mins.	Exercise: Enacting inner motivation	Presenting, rehearsing, and reflecting on acting technique and improvisation	Improvised acting through a character's inner motivation	Role cards with built in motivated conflict
3	30 mins.	Identifying challenging practice	Sharing experiences and identification of material for a scenario	None (framed as storytelling)	None
4	30-45 mins.	Composing performance and characters	Using shared experiences to compose a three-minute, partly improvised performance.	Composition/ built in conflict. Character's inner motivation.	Step-guide supporting composition
5	20 mins. for each loop	Performance and reflections	Investigating perspectives and possible solutions and futures	Improvised acting Spectactors	None
6	30 mins.	Wrap-up	Sharing experiences on learning within, with, and from "As If"	None (dialogue in class)	None

Table 1. Playing with roles – an example of a teaching session

P6

PLAYING WITH KNOWING

– opportunities and challenges in the classroom

BY LOTTE AGNES LAUSEN

Lotte Agnes Lausen, Ph.d., founder and owner of Intellectual Craft. This article is based on Lausen's PhD project: Playing With Ways of Knowing - Play, Atmosphere and Experience in Danish Teacher Education.

When you experience teaching that awakens your senses, stirs your imagination and resonates with your own experiences in different ways, it may seem obvious that this type of teaching is a good way of being together – in the classroom as educators and students. At the same time, it can be perceived as a good approach to teaching and learning. However, when it comes to defining and perhaps even defending the exact point of it all, it can be difficult – like when talking about play itself – to pinpoint what playfulness in the classroom is actually all about and how it contributes to learning.

My research in the context of teacher education points to how, in the demanding work of designing and devising new and playful ways of doing things in the classroom, there is an opportunity to play with ways of knowing (Lausen, 2023).

The importance of playing with ways of knowing

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On the social education and teacher education programmes, the educators' daily work in and outside the classroom, i.e. their efforts to educate and train students for their future professional roles, must reflect this goal. Students need knowledge about the *theoretical perspectives* of their profession as well as *knowledge about the physical practice that is rooted in action*, enabling them to act competently in their future professional practice.

In this way, these forms of knowledge are inseparable in university college education, while at the same time representing different ways of knowing (Lausen, 2023). Playing with ways of knowing, by designing teaching practices through play, helps to equip students to continuously design different types of learning spaces for children (Boysen et al., 2022, p. 1).

To even talk about the importance of playing with ways of knowing only makes sense if one subscribes to an understanding of knowing and learning as being dependent on sociomaterial, bodily, spatial and sensory engagement and on the individual student's continued opportunities for participation in the knowledge process. It is an understanding of knowledge and learning that has been advanced over time by various theorists from John Dewey onwards. This understanding of learning as an *active* process, of knowledge and learning as a continuous activity *done* by students, enables an understanding of how students can come to know, depending on how teaching practices are unfolded in different ways. In other words, different ways of engaging and participating in teaching practices offer different ways of knowing for students in the classroom. At the same time, designing teaching practices through play also offers special opportunities for attuning stu-

dents towards *playing* with different ways of knowing.

The play mood perspective

Most educators have knowledge of and take an interest in different learning and development theories as a background for their teaching. In the same way, when designing teaching practices through play, having an underlying theoretical understanding of play can be valuable. Most play theorists agree that play is a universal human activity. Based on an understanding of play as a fundamental and universal human part of being human, the theorist Gordon M. Burghardt (2005) even goes so far as to argue that play must be taken as seriously as, for example, psychological and neuroscientific perspectives on learning – in order to get an understanding of the whole person in educational and teaching contexts.

In my research on designing teaching practices through play, I have used the definition of play as a mood practice (Skovbjerg, 2021). Play as a mood practice is, in short, an understanding that play comes about through interaction between a number of different dimensions. Play arises between three dimensions: the play materials or media with which we play; the play practices used in play, or how something is done with the play materials; and the involvement and experience of the individual participants in the play activity (Skovbjerg, 2021). The mood perspective proves valuable to our understanding of playful teaching practices by contributing three specific dimensions of play that can be used to design teaching practices through play: play media, play practices and play moods.

Moving closer to the concept of mood from the play mood perspective, it becomes apparent that it is important for the educator be aware that playful moods can never be forced, but must emerge in the interaction between the educator, the students and the material and spatial configurations of the teaching situation. The individual's mood cannot be controlled, but educators can seek to attune students towards playing with ways of knowing by designing teaching practices through play. In this context, the three dimensions – media, practices and mood – become concrete tools we can work with. Opportunities can be created for attuning students towards playing with ways of knowing – with the help of these tools – by focusing on playing with different practices and playing with different media or materials in class. Through these different ways of doing things, it is also possible to focus on how students participate in different ways in the playful practices.

An example could be a biology class with student teachers. Here there is a difference between how Karla and Axel can know when they are out in the field, standing in a river in waders, and are asked to taste the water, smell it and explore the heath around the river, and how they will be able to know if they are sitting in a classroom, reflecting together on the course and water quality of the river, distanced from a sensory experience of it. However, playing with ways of knowing, by focusing on different playful, sensory and creative experiences, is not reserved for moving out of the classroom.

Students point out that different, playful and sensory experiences in more traditional classroom settings contribute in the same way to them becoming playfully attuned towards different ways of knowing. These experiences can take many forms – students teaching their peers, exploring a theoretical

perspective by playing 'Spin the Bottle', playing with different materials and technologies, writing fictitious diaries under the tables in the classroom.

Possibilities in designing through play

Inviting playful teaching practices can thus create opportunities for students to do things in different and creative ways in the classroom and thus gain different theoretical, practical and sensory experiences with the subject matter they are working with. In this way, inviting playful teaching designs into the classroom shares important characteristics and cohesive elements with, for example, experience-based and aesthetic teaching philosophies.

Playful teaching designs – intended to attune the students towards playing with ways of knowing – can contribute to these more established teaching fields or approaches. This is done, among other things, by creating a teaching frame without long-term consequences outside of the frame, and what can be termed the open production of meaning. These two important dimensions of what playful teaching practices can contribute are closely linked and will be explained in more detail in the following.

A frame with no long-term consequences

In order for the individual, not least adults, to experience a situation as playful, the activities engaged in must be perceived as not having long-term consequences (Apter, 1990). We know this from playing games like chess or ludo. We are totally immersed in the game, and while we are playing it matters to us whether we win or not. The fact that winning matters to us while we are playing is part of the driving force of the game. However, in normal situations, when we are just playing for fun, the outcomes of our actions have no long-term consequences for us afterwards.

In teaching contexts, this means that the activities in which students participate should not be experienced as having consequences outside of the frame within which the teaching unfolds. The teaching frame and content must be designed in such a way that the activities in which students participate do not have any negative impact on their future opportunities, their performance at exams, assessments by teachers and fellow students or other elements that may be perceived as negative consequences of participating in the activities here and now, over and above participating and playing along. Awareness of how play can only be made possible through the feeling that there are no consequences associated with one's own actions turns out to be particularly helpful in creating a space where students have the opportunity to consider and question their own attitudes, values and preconceptions as regards theoretical perspectives as well as their own future professional practice. This is linked to the open production of meaning, which is the other important aspect of what playful teaching designs have to offer.

Open production of meaning

The open production of meaning is an important aspect of what playful teaching designs have to offer in the classroom. At the same time, it is an essential aspect of how to make playfulness possible at all – as a safe environment without long-term consequences.

The open production of meaning must be understood in the sense that, when designing teaching practices through play, there must always be an openness about how meaning can be produced among the participants. In the play-as-a-mood-practice perspective, it is explained how this openness is created through those who participate in the play: They are open to the idea of both materials and practices carrying multiple meanings.

A well-known example for most people is the way that, when playing, a pot can both function and make sense as a pot, but suddenly also work as a helmet or a drum. In the teaching context, this means that the topics, materials and practices worked with must be able to take on multiple meanings, and there must be a special openness to the interpretation of practices and media. Playing with theories, perspectives or, for example, practical action experiences in the classroom means that there must be room to play with their meanings, rather than the meanings being given in advance. In this way, meaning is constructed and negotiated through the situated social practices in the classroom.

Students become central participants in the construction of meaning in the classroom. When playing with our understanding of the topics that we are working with, the valuable thing about designing teaching practices through play is how diverse aspects of and perspectives on the topics are allowed to emerge. In this way, knowledge about designing teaching practices through play is not about students knowing in a specific way or producing a specific meaning, but rather about creating new meanings here and now by playing with the knowledge that is being worked with. The open production of meaning allows students to move away from insisting on 'the right answer' or the right understanding of a theory. More specifically, playful approaches allow students to be open to taking chances and to trying things out, being curious, and questioning and playing with the meaning of practices and materials in different and new ways.

When designing teaching practices through play, the open production of meaning, the negotiation of meaning in relation to different topics, becomes possible when the playful teaching frame contributes to creating a certain mood in the classroom: Here, the opinions that are exchanged are not going to influence the students' future opportunities, and they cannot subsequently be evaluated as being mistaken. In this way, a safe space is created where activities are perceived as being without long-term consequences. This is connected to the playful and open production of meaning, while at the same time being a prerequisite for such production taking place. When designing teaching practices through play, the focus must be on playing with ways of knowing here and now – through being curious about the possibility of producing new meanings.

Points of attention when inviting students to be playful

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Concrete suggestions for ways in which educators can invite students into a playful teaching frame can be to emphasise that "we're just playing"; to invite experimentation; and to contribute to the students' understanding of the importance of different ways of knowing in relation to their future professional practice.

When educators invite students into a playful teaching frame, it is also important

that the playful premise is upheld throughout the teaching session or course. If the students' playful activities are evaluated outside of the playful premise for the open production of meaning and playing with ways of knowing, students may lose faith that the playful teaching designs are quite as playful as they were initially made out to be.

At the same time, it is important when designing and inviting teaching practices through play to acknowledge the students' possible ambivalence towards participating and 'playing along' on the above premises. In recognition of the students' possible ambivalence towards putting themselves at risk, playing along and being open to possible ways of knowing, some interesting reflections and discussions can arise about the students' values, norms and preconceptions about what it means to play, learn, know and teach. Especially when a safe space is created where it is safe to reflect openly on this possible ambivalence.

Challenges and opportunities of play are interconnected

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As already indicated above, opportunities for playing with ways of knowing in the classroom are often, for both students and educators, interconnected with the challenges associated with doing so.

Educators may find themselves considering a number of questions: *Will anything be achieved by letting students play with flamingo, cardboard or design their own playful teaching practice? How can these practices be justified when there is a syllabus to get through and exams to pass?* These questions point to a real challenge – whether there is really enough time to unfold different and time-consuming practices and play with different materialities in the classroom. Considerations and challenges to do with pressures of time are important and prevalent among educators seeking to design teaching practices through play.

Due to full lesson plans that must be executed within an optimistic time frame, educators may feel pressurised into giving priority to less time-consuming teaching processes. In many cases, such pressures can result in teaching practices involving less active student participation, as student participation takes time – and student participation is an essential part of playful teaching designs.

The challenge of finding the time to invite playfulness into the classroom is closely associated with another challenge, that of how playful teaching designs can fuel doubts about the right way of practising knowledge. The design of teaching practices through play is often associated with some ambivalence about which ways of knowing are valued in the classroom. This should not be understood as an ambivalence on the part of individual educators, but as a cultural, historical and social ambivalence in relation to the practices associated with and most often prioritised in higher education. Such ambivalence towards knowledge and teaching can make it more difficult for educators to prioritise playful teaching practices.

However, the challenge of how knowledge can and preferably should be practised in the classroom is interweaved with an opportunity for educators. In the possible ambivalence about which practices may be justified in the classroom, about how knowledge is best practised, lies an opportunity to share this ambivalence with students and thus engage students in some of the educator's underlying didactic reflections. In this way, the challenge in the

form of ambivalence regarding possible ways of practising teaching and knowledge can be addressed and discussed more explicitly with students. The explicit sharing of reflections on this ambivalence can serve as a basis for pointing to these reflections as an often inevitable part of planning different types of learning spaces, for the benefit of students in their own future professional practice.

Final thoughts

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The design of playful teaching practices offers opportunities for playing with the sensory, experiential, material and spatial dimensions of the learning process as a way of playing with ways of knowing within a safe, exploratory and experimental framework.

The argument is that in order to fulfil their future professional roles, students on both the social education and teacher education programmes need different ways of knowing, not only theoretical, but also sensory, bodily and experience-based ways. One way of facilitating this is through the design of teaching practices through play. In order to create room for designing teaching practices through play in social education and teacher education, educators need continuous, organisational and political support to validate and prioritise this task.

Despite these significant prerequisites and challenges for the unfolding of playful teaching designs in social education and teacher education, it is important to bear in mind that some of the opportunities for playing with ways of knowing are found in our daily teaching practices. Together with students, educators can continuously experiment with allowing space and time for doing things differently and thus for unfolding important opportunities for playing with different and new ways of knowing in university college education.

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P7

LET THE BODY DO THE TALKING

– a teaching design to promote awareness of kinesthetic empathy

BY SISSE WINTHER ORESKOV

Sisse Winther Oreskov, Associate Professor and PhD at University College Absalon. This article is based on Oreskov's PhD project: Kunsten at sætte sig kropsligt i den andens sted: kinæstetisk empati i pædagogisk kontekst. (The Art of Placing Us 'Inside' the Other's Kinesthetic Experience: Kinesthetic Empathy in a Pedagogical Context).

Based on my PhD project *Kunsten at sætte sig kropsligt i den andens sted – Kinæstetisk empati i pædagogisk kontekst*, I will describe in this article how I, together with students and educators on the social education programme, have created an educational design that can support the students' awareness of kinesthetically empathic modes of action. Before describing the design, I will first outline the important role of the body in learning processes. Then I will explain what kinesthetic empathy is and why it is a concept that is relevant both to research and to teach in social education.

Body and learning

Since Aristotle described his idea of phronesis, which is characterised by practical-ethical wisdom or wisdom in action, the importance of the body for learning and knowledge acquisition has been described in a number of different ways. Schön (2001) talks about the reflective practitioner and the concept of reflection-in-action; phenomenologists such as van Manen (2002; 2022) argue in favour of focusing on the role of the body in education; and the relatively young research field of *embodied cognition* has contributed to drawing attention to the importance of the body in the learning process.

Nevertheless, there is still a long way to go before this knowledge will be manifested in dominant teaching practices. There can be many reasons for this. As pointed out by Gallagher (2018), this may be because the classroom is under the influence of the ghost of Descartes, and therefore forms of knowledge other than agentive and sensory forms of knowledge are given priority and value. This can manifest, for example, in the way in which the pre-reflexive and tacit evaluation of the classroom by students as well as educators contributes to undermining the value of agentive and sensory forms of knowledge – by not attaching equal value to physical and linguistic practice (Lausen et al., 2022). However, this is a problem on educational programmes such as the social education programme because:

> *During their studies, student teachers and student social educators heading for a future role in professional physical practice* [...] *need knowledge to be practised in ways that clarify and tie these two forms of practice together: linguistic expertise and practical expertise. For them as future practitioners, it is through practical action that the language of the profession proves its worth, both in concrete situations and when subsequently reflecting on such situations* (Lausen et al., 2022, p. 28).

On professional bachelor's programmes, for example on the social education programme, we must always keep in mind that

the analytical distinction between an actual physical practice and a linguistic practice must not be in opposition to each other, and we must didactically try to transcend this dichotomy. I have tried to do this by developing an educational design that focuses on supporting the students' awareness of kinesthetically empathic modes of action.

Kinesthetic empathy

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The focal point of my research has been the concept of kinesthetic empathy. My interest in the concept springs from observations of social educators working with children and the role played by the body in this context (Oreskov, 2019). Kinesthetic empathy is crucial for the quality of the work of social educators as empathy is closely linked to the caring and ethical aspects of their work.

In a compilation of knowledge about the professional practice of social educators in Denmark from 2004 to 2019, Togsverd and Aabro (2020) identified four dimensions of importance to the professional competency of social educators that can be deduced from the scientific literature: thinking, knowing, agency and sensing. The mapping shows that sensory and sensing forms of knowledge are crowded out by other dimensions. As part of my research, I therefore set out to contribute to drawing attention to the importance of these forms of knowledge in a pedagogical context, and I chose kinesthetic empathy as a starting point for this work.

Kinesthetic empathy can be described as an agentive and sensory form of knowledge that is important in the pedagogical encounter between social educators and children or citizens. It provides the social educator with insight into the child's experience, while meeting the child at a nonverbal kinesthetic level, which facilitates the child's connection to the integrated self and thereby to others (Rova, 2017). Kinesthetic empathy can be described as epistemologically placing oneself 'inside' another person's corporeal experience and, on the basis of one's own body topography, gaining knowledge about the other person's situation or experience (Parviainen, 2003).

Our body topography can be seen as the experiences with which we encounter other people's experiences. It is dynamic and shaped in different ways depending on individual, cultural and social differences. For student social educators, it will thus also be shaped by and developed during their studies. The changeability of the body topography is one of the reasons why kinesthetic empathy is relevant in an educational context: because the way we teach and the experience and experiences gained and had by students during their studies have a bearing on the possible modes of action that students will be able to practise in their future work as social educators.

My research indicates that kinesthetically empathic modes of action in the context of social education are characterised by the social educator being sensually present in the encounter with the child, registering her own corporeal sensations, reflecting on her own body topography, aligning herself kinesthetically with the child, communicating kinesthetically and witnessing and mirroring the child (Oreskov, 2024).

An educational design with a focus on kinesthetically empathic modes of action opens up new possibilities with a focus on agentive and sensory forms of knowledge on the social education programme. Why this is important I will describe in the following.

The importance of working with kinesthetically empathic modes of action

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I have described how kinesthetically empathic modes of action are important when it comes to providing the educator with insight into the child's experiences and situation, and also that being met with kinesthetic empathy is crucial for the child's development. We are all capable of kinesthetic empathy, but it is also a skill that can be cultivated (Rova, 2017). This in itself is an argument for working with kinesthetic empathy on the social education programme. At the same time, my research shows that for some students, practising kinesthetic empathy is not possible in certain situations.

These situations are characterised by what Birkmose (2013) describes as brutalisation. It is described as "a process in which individuals become increasingly cruel, brutal, cold and cynical in their thinking, reactions and thus in their personality structure" (translated from Danish) (p. 15). This is expressed, for example, in Aya's description of a two-year-old nursery child by the name of M, whose language is not age-appropriate:

M is often easily upset, or at least becomes so, if he doesn't get his way. I can empathise with him because it's not fun not being able to play or get exactly what you want. Still, quite often I get a little dismissive when he comes to me wanting 'sympathy'. We all do as he often gets upset or angry for no reason. Because he doesn't understand what we're saying to him, it's often really difficult to talk to him about things compared to what it is like with the other children. This is not a one-off, but something that happens daily, and sometimes even many times in the course of the day (Oreskov, 2024, p. 203).

It is clear from Aya's description of the experience that she is not putting herself in M's place, and that she lacks an understanding of the challenges M is experiencing because he is not able to express himself verbally. The description is indicative of a culture in the institution where consensus has developed that M is whiny and that he tends to get upset or angry for no reason. It is therefore normal for Aya and her colleagues to be dismissive of him.

Such an approach becomes possible if you are not present in the moment in the ways that characterise kinesthetically empathetic modes of action, i.e if you are not sensually present in the encounter with M, and if you are therefore not registering your own corporeal sensations in the encounter with him. If you were present in this way, it could lead to reflections on your own body topography, including reflections such as: Why do I describe M as whiny, and why do I think it is appropriate to meet him in a dismissive way? The description of the experience is also devoid of examples of Aya aligning herself kinesthetically with M, communicating kinesthetically and witnessing and mirroring M.

Focusing on the practice of kinesthetically empathic modes of action can help prevent the brutalisation seen to be happening in the care professions.

Structure of the educational design

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The 'Let the body do the talking' educational design was created through five iterations together with educators and students on the social education programme, and is based on the knowledge about kinesthetic empathy and body and learning outlined above (Oreskov, 2024). The purpose of the design is to support



Figure 1. The overall structure of the educational design.

a process in which agentive and sensory forms of knowledge are carried into a reflective professional space. This is done by dwelling on the sensory experience associated with teaching with play qualities, and reflecting on how the experience can contribute to qualifying student social educators' approach to their professional practice. The structure of the design is outlined in Figure 1.

The design is based on teaching with play qualities, where the body is involved and actively engaged. This starting point has been chosen because through playful practices an opening is created to a sensory landscape and a sensory mood, which is conducive to directing the attention towards agentive and sensory forms of knowledge (Austring & Sørensen, 2006; Hohr, 1996; Skovbjerg & Jørgensen, 2021; Thorsted & Hansen, 2022). This can be seen, for example, when students attune to each other through making eye and body contact, when they concentrate on making a body sculpture together, or when the room is filled with laughter or screams, when playful actions make the room euphoric. Through a mediating factor, the students' attention is directed towards the theme that is most relevant based on their first-person experience in the teaching situation.

For this purpose, a set of dialogue cards has been created covering 27 different themes, which the students use as a starting point for interviewing each other. The dialogue cards cover the following themes: insecurity, security, fear, courage, contact, anger, joy, lack of creativity, spontaneity, impatience, patience, irritation, full of energy, transgressive, sense of presence, judgmental, acceptance, feeling drained, curiosity, uncertainty, lack of competence, resourceful, openness, grounded, concentrated, strength and balanced.

Educational design in practice

Let me present an example of how the design can unfold. A teacher by the name of Lotte has started an activity that involves the students being out on the floor and having to follow someone they do not know, saying their name. The student has to make a movement that is then copied by the other person. At some point, the two students, without saying anything to each other, must agree to hit each other on the head with the foam tube that they have in their hand, as a signal to move on and meet someone new:

Music that supports movement is played, and the room is full of energy and laughter. After a

while, some of the students have lined up along the wall, while others are still at it. "Keep going," says Lotte, as she keeps moving around on the floor herself. "It smells of sweat and it's airless in here," says one student, and another student adds: "This is all a bit much." "Keep going," says Lotte while dancing towards the door. A number of students have gone outside. "Come on, get back in here" [...] *"I sense that some of you are no longer joining in, ask yourself why this is?" A student answers: "I think we started out at too fast a pace." Another says: "I'm out because it's too much, so I'm out. I don't like doing this sort of thing in front of others." Lotte replies while still moving around: "In your professional practice, you will be working with others and relations, you know." "We're trying," says one student, and another continues: "It's okay with children, but it's different with all of you. It's also about self-control, it's not fun letting go in front of other people"* (Oreskov, 2024, p. 226).

Based on their participation in the teaching with play quality, the students must now, from a number of different artefacts, choose one that they associate with their experience of participating in the activity. The artefact serves as a mediating factor, helping to translate the sensory experience into a linguistic one. The mediating factor can take many forms, for example it could be cards with different pictures, drawings or, as in the following, a number of different artefacts.

Hanne, who was among the students who ended up standing along the wall and not participating in the activity towards the end, looks at the various artefacts and picks up a tube of glue, while Kasper, who had been dancing around very energetically, picks up a train engine. Going on to look at the dialogue cards with the 27 different themes, Hanne translates her artefact into the 'uncertainty' card, while Kasper picks the 'joy' card. Kasper then has 25 minutes to interview Hanne based on the questions on her card with the 'uncertainty' theme, after which they switch roles.

The first part of the dialogue card focuses on the individual sensory experience, and Kasper will ask Hanne the following questions:

- Find an example from the situation where you had a feeling of uncertainty.
- Where and how does it feel in your body?
- What can uncertainty look like as a movement/bodily expression in you? Demonstrate it to your partner.
- Do you recognise the corporeal experience of uncertainty from (other) situations in your pedagogical work? Give concrete examples.
- What is your strategy when you experience uncertainty?
- Is it an appropriate strategy, or is there something you would like to work on doing differently?

In the second part of the dialogue card, the focus is on the children or citizens the social educator works with:

- How do you sense other people's uncertainty in your pedagogical work?
- What do you do to accommodate and meet other people's feelings of insecurity in your pedagogical work?
- What happens to your feelings of insecurity when you are with others?

In the last and third part of the dialogue card, the focus is on reflecting on how the knowledge gained based on the corporeal experience from the activity can contribute to qualifying the individual student's pedagogical practice as well as the practice that the student will become part of in their working

lives. This is achieved through the following questions:

- What is uncertainty for you? Explain what you mean by uncertainty in a pedagogical context.
- What knowledge have you gained from your corporeal experience of uncertainty that is important to you on your (educational) journey to becoming a social educator? Present it as three bullets.
- Going forward, what can you do to work with your feeling of uncertainty in your pedagogical practice? Formulate a single specific development point that you want to work with in the future.
- How can the knowledge you have gained through the above dialogue help to qualify your pedagogical practice? For example, does it give rise to discussing rules or concepts that you know from your pedagogical practice? Be specific.

After the interview, both students write a brief summary of important points from their dialogue. The interviewee also makes a note of the three insights as well as the development point formulated during the interview.

Where can the educational design be used?

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The educational design is designed for teaching with play qualities, where the body is actively engaged. But it can also be used in connection with study days during internship periods, where the students work with activities that they have done with children or citizens during their internship, rather than class-based activities. As the students are often unfamiliar with working with agentive and sensory forms of knowledge, it is a good idea to use the educational design several times to make sure that the students become more accustomed to working professionally with agentive and sensory forms of knowledge.

Throughout the project, I have observed many students working with the design. Quite a few students became very interested in the dialogues facilitated by the dialogue cards. Among other things, they say that the cards have helped them put into words corporeal sensations that can otherwise be difficult to talk about, and that they have had some in-deep dialogues about their professional practice. These points are substantiated by feedback received from educators(Oreskov, 2024). But there are also students, like Mille, who find it difficult to work with the dialogue cards. When I interviewed her, she said, among other things:

It was a little abstract, a little too vague to get to grips with – after all you want to think the right thing (Oreskov, 2024, p. 253).

There may be several reasons why Mille finds it difficult. It may be because she is not familiar with working with agentive and sensing forms of knowledge in a professional context, and because focusing on personal processes involving wondering, doubting and questioning your own practice feels challenging. However, as van Manen (2022) points out: "Pedagogy is these questions and these doubts" (translated from Danish) (p. 27), and we must train the students to be in that space. The educational design presented can be a path to achieving this, and it is crucial that the educator thinks carefully about the way students are introduced to working with the design. For example, by using a relevant text in connection with the work with agentive and sensory forms of knowledge, or by

providing examples of possible answers to the questions.

Similarly, it is important to ensure that the work with the educational design is concluded in a way that takes the learning process seriously. This can be done, for example, by reflecting together on the insights gained through working with the dialogue cards and on the development points that the students will focus on going forward. This can also be done by discussing how the students' dialogues (supported by the dialogue cards) can contribute to reflections on rules or concepts that they are familiar with from their pedagogical practice.

As part of the P+L Praxis project, the dialogue cards have been printed and distributed to all social education and teacher education programmes in Denmark. This makes it possible to use them in situations similar to those described in this text, or to test them in new contexts.

Do you want to try the design?

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Find it at playful-learning.dk

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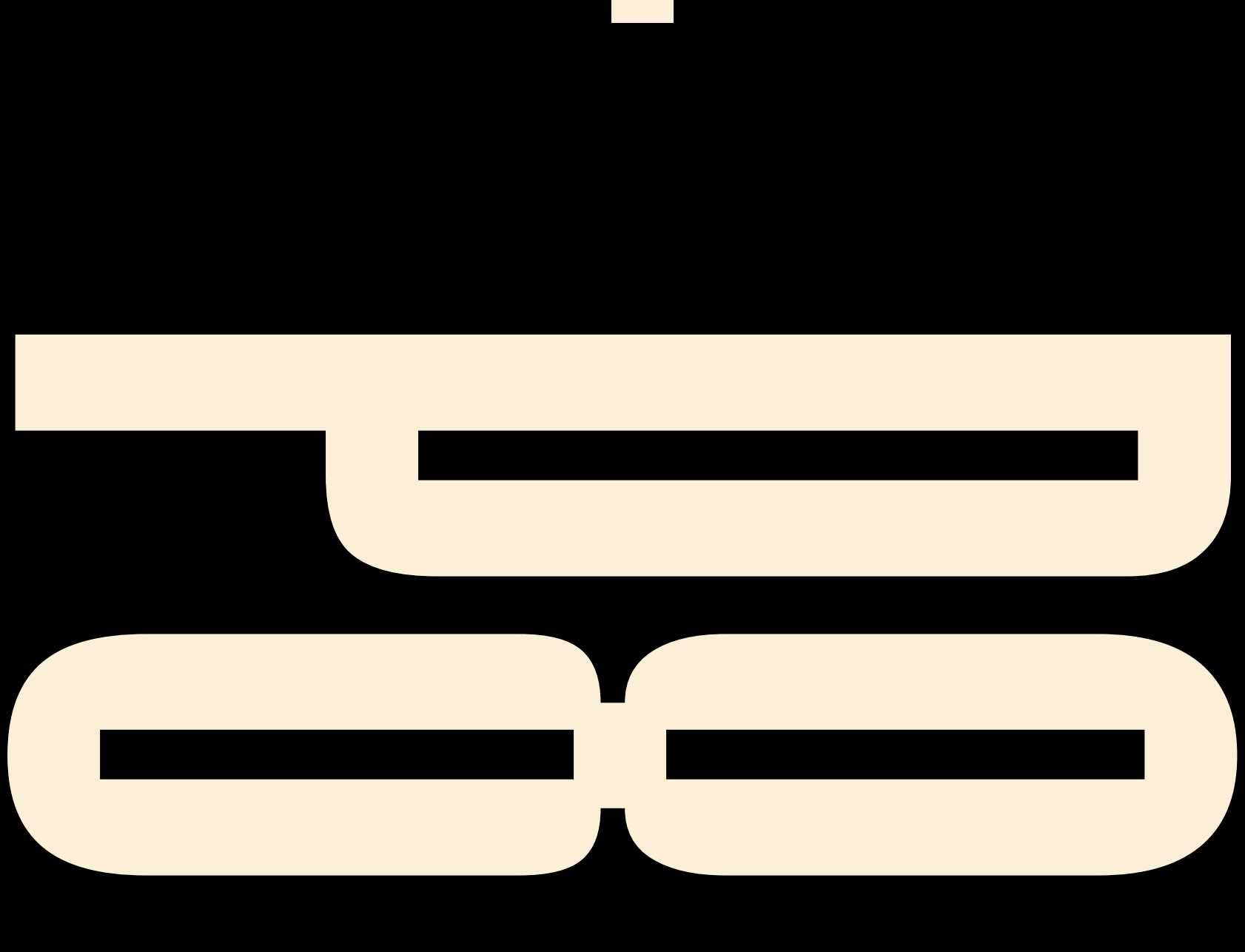
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PLAYFUL MOVEMENTS CAN SPREAD LIKE RIPPLES IN THE WATER

BY LARS DAHL PEDERSEN

Lars Dahl Pedersen, PhD and Assistant Professor at University College Absalon. This article is based on Pedersen's PhD project: Legende bevægelser i et koreografisk perspektiv - designbaserede undersøgelser af danse- og bevægelsespraksisser på pædagoguddannelsen (Playful Movements in a Choreographic Perspective -Design-based Research on Dance and Movement Practices in Social Education).

There is no such thing as right and wrong. The ideal is open to interpretation. I thought that was actually a cool thought to keep in mind. It was fun realising that you could actually be captivated by something other than just competition, but also this sense of your own flexibility and feeling yourself (Jacob, student on the social education programme, June 2021).

The above quote stems from interviews conducted during a series of dance and movement experiments in the classroom of the social education programme as part of my PhD project *Legende bevægelser i et koreografisk perspektiv - designbaserede undersøgelser af danse- og bevægelsespraksisser på pædagoguddannelsen* (Pedersen, 2024b).

Based on my professional experience as a dancer and choreographer, I have used choreography as a lens to look at playful and improvised movements. The PhD project has resulted in an article-based dissertation, in which I use design experiments on movement practices to investigate what it means to be playful with one's body – with a particular focus on social education. It is a key finding of the thesis that movement situations with a degree of indeterminacy and mischievousness can give students the courage to participate in communities centred around playful movement – and dancing and being playful is part of the relational work of social educators.

This article is about engaging in playful movement with others – and its relevance to the education of social educators and their professional practice. I start by discussing how mastering one's playful and moving body can be considered an essential skill of social educators. I do this to highlight the potential of the social educator's own physicality in their interaction with different target groups and citizens. I then present three episodes from the classroom, where three students with different bodily styles succeed in 'contaminating' their fellow students with playful movements. However, for us as adults, stepping step forward and moving playfully in front of others often comes with certain challenges. Being able to move playfully in front of and together with others is not always 'child's play' – especially not for students on an academised social education programme. Finally, I introduce a special choreographic perspective that I have developed in my dissertation aimed at spotting playful movement patterns.

Absence of playful movement mastery

A number of the competence objectives of the modules of the current social education programme revolve around doing something with pedagogical environments and activities. In the executive order governing the social education programme, many different verbs

are used to explicate what students must be able to do with pedagogical environments and activities, including: goal-setting, planning, framing, establishing, creating, implementing, managing, developing, assessing, documenting, evaluating and analysing (Danish Ministry of Higher Education and Science, 2017). Thus, the competence objectives of the programme suggest that social educators must be able to carry out a carefully designed and planned process, starting with setting goals for and developing an activity and then implementing it and finally evaluating and analysing it.

In my PhD project, I have been curious about those communities in the professional practice of social educators where meanings and goals are not given in advance. Because the everyday practice of social educators is not just about planned activities with goals that have been determined by the social educator in advance. Just think of the many human encounters where meaning only arises through what we do together.

According to the German philosopher Hans Georg Gadamer (2007), whose concept of play includes music, dance and acting, an essential characteristic of play is that it cannot be controlled, and it can be attractive to us precisely because of its unpredictability. When engaging in play, we must risk being overwhelmed, which is also what makes play attractive for us to participate in. My focus is on the type of play where the participants are creative and physically active with their bodies, and in this article I am interested in understanding what kind of social education skills are needed and how they can be practised on an educational programme.

This is not the first time that mastery of practical-musical forms of expression has been seen in the context of the education of social educators. The artistic subject areas used to play a key role in social education, but over the 1987-2014 period, music, movement-related subjects, drama, natural science and workshop activities as independent subject areas were reduced from 700 hours over three years, to students now being able to almost completely avoid these subjects (Hansen, 2020). It used to be a central idea that social educators, through the mastery of creative forms of expression, could inspire the participants in a pedagogical environment to discover their own creative power. However, the current curriculum contains no descriptions of how the mastery of practical-musical modes of expression, such as dance, music or visual arts, can – in itself and often in surprising ways – lead to the creation of pedagogical environments and activities.

On the other hand, the executive order and the curriculum do not specifically state that aspiring social educators should completely refrain from using their own body and artistic expression. However, the non-mention of the importance of mastering playful movement can easily leave the impression that a social educator can get away with being a sedentary adult on the edge of any activity. Today, there is thus an increased focus on social educators as planners and evaluators – rather than social educators as physically and creatively active.

Three different movement styles that are contagious

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There is something inherently contradictory in the understanding of being *playful with your body in imperfect ways* as a form of mastery. During my fieldwork on the social education programme, I have learned that standing up

and moving in playful ways in front of others takes a certain amount of courage and daring. Such movement is not always associated with specific technical skills. Social educators are not trained to become professional dancers, but to be professionals in working with relations. However, the experience of movement students bring with them to the programme plays an important role.

In my movement experiments, I have encountered students of social education who in very different ways succeeded in contaminating their fellow students, making them want to participate in bodily and playful movement interactions. The three students in the following three episodes, in particular, have inspired me and made me understand how differently the contagious, playful body can be expressed (Pedersen, 2024a).

1. Unexpected everyday movements

In an experiment about being aware of the distance between you and others, one of the students, Rebecca, is suddenly the one allowed by the others to dictate their movements. In the experiment, the participants are asked to walk around among each other and to form an equilateral triangle with two (secretly chosen) partners. Once everyone is standing still in equilateral triangles, the task is complete. As Rebecca happens to take an extra step forward, suddenly the rest of the group moves with her. She then chooses, seemingly on purpose, to take an extra big step forward. Again, her action evokes immediate reactions – everyone else reflexively take a step in different directions. There is a lot of laughter. Rebecca then starts moving around with folded arms and taking big steps from side to side and back, like a little waltz, and the other students follow, greatly amused.

The episode and Rebecca's appearance show that easily reproducible and recognisable everyday movements (e.g. walking, running, crawling, jumping) in combination with understated leadership quickly spread like a contagion to others. The group quickly turns into a playfully moving unit whose members enjoy moving around together, and with a strong sense of community. The sense of community arises easily through the use of simple movements that are quickly mastered by everybody – like a kind of playful regiment moving in step with each other.

2. Transforming technical skill into bodily uncontrollability

In another episode, I introduce the students to a structured movement improvisation, which among other things is about practising moving fluidly with one's whole body close to the floor. As an example, I choose to demonstrate a technically demanding sequence of movements, floatingly rolling over one shoulder and back again over the other shoulder. While most of the students are hesitant, one of the students, Sasha, seizes the initiative and starts practising the sequence. She ends up rolling her body into a dead end and with both legs above her head, after which she starts repeating to her body: "Over one shoulder and back again," but her body is totally stuck. Several students start following Sasha's lead, and suddenly everyone is lying on the floor in various awkward positions, talking and laughing.

Sasha's courage to fail drove the others to engage in the activity. She transformed a focus on technical skill into daring to fail, and the others started feeling like joining in. Instead of executing the sequence to perfection, together the students end up creating

a surprising sculptural landscape of twisted, folded and laughing bodies. Unlike the first example, the movements initiated by Sasha do not result in identical and unison forms of expressions in the group. But the folded bodies move twistedly towards each other, ready for touching, being playfully pushed around and shared breathing, like a single dynamic body.

3. Excessive imagination with rhythmic repetitions

The third contagious bodily form of expression I want to highlight came about while a group of students and I were trying to come up with ideas for ways in which a seated audience can also be physically active, for example by occasionally changing places. In this situation, one of the students, Jonas, takes the initiative by suddenly getting up from his chair, and then dancingly moving past two of his fellow students to a vacant seat. He sits down briefly and then dances back to his original seat, all the while singing: "Flee, flee, come with me." Several of the students just sit there, speechlessly watching. "It's a bit like a game of musical chairs," says Jonas, singing as he jumps up from his chair again: "So that's the game, we talk with our arms, and they do the same." He coordinates his movements as he moves from chair to chair while singing his improvised poem.

At this moment, with his imagination and enthusiasm, Jonas stands out from the other students. Jonas' exaggerated, playful movements do not seem to 'catch on' with the others, and initially his fellow students are left speechless. This may be due to his highly coordinated movement language, which clearly exudes a kind of technical skill. And at the same time, he breaks into singing and dancing at a markedly different pace to the others in the room, as if possessed by a special dance fever. In fact, one of the students even asks him afterwards what he had for breakfast. A sign that the other students are hesitant about standing out from the crowd – unlike Jonas.

Jonas transforms playfulness into dancing through his convincing and exaggerated movements, making his improvisation look like a rehearsed performance. At first, the rest of the students seem paralysed. But slowly, as the lesson progresses, everyone joins in the alternative game of musical chairs for audiences. With his surprising, rhythmic dancing, Jonas manages to hack the teaching situation for both the students and the educator. He is an example of a student who lives on the edge of teaching, and in a way he acts neither as student nor as teacher.

Often, my authority as an educator or instructor will get in the way of being able to do what Jonas does. Moreover, my focus on keeping the lesson on track is challenged; by allowing time and space for Jonas' performance, I run the risk of the lesson plan falling apart. The episode shows that the combination of good movement skills with imaginative and surprising ideas can contribute to developing a movement activity in a new and playful direction.

Three ideas for gateways to creating unexpected and playful movement communities

Many students do not perceive dance as being related to play – especially not when having to perform or show off in front of their fellow students. This point became particularly clear to me during one of my first visits to the social education programme as a PhD student. After my introduction to what I myself perceived

as a particularly playful dance improvisation, one of the students said: "I'd actually rather jump out the window than dance." (Pedersen, 2023, p. 236).

However, my conclusion is not that one should refrain from introducing challenging movement tasks on the social education programme. Like many other subject elements on the programme, playful dance activities can be seen as new content that the students must gradually master. The three episodes show three very different ways in which playful movement communities can develop in the classroom. They point to the fact that playful dancing can spread contagiously and in different ways and with different bodily styles when students are allowed to act as playleaders who are keen to contaminate their fellow students. Focusing on different bodily styles, the three episodes can be summarised as follows:

1. Recognisable everyday movements, combined with understated leadership, can quickly lead to all participants moving joyfully around together.
2. When a focus on technical skills is transformed into humorous, uncontrollable and asynchronous bodily forms of expression, it can seem like a contagious invitation, enticing you to join in simply for the sake of company.
3. Surprising breaks in the rhythm of movement and breaks from what you usually do in the room can deliver a small, surprising shock to the other participants, who little by little let themselves be carried away by imaginative approaches to dance and movement.

Playful dancing courage

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Playfulness can be associated with a feeling of uncertainty, which can be difficult to handle, if you have already decided how you want to move. Many of the statements by students indicate that they are very aware of each other's bodies and not least their own body in relation to the bodies of others. This is evident, among other things, from the fact that some would rather learn a rehearsed choreography than have to express themselves in more unpredictable ways with their body in the classroom. The students are also trying to make sense of the activities and to make them fit in with the many intended learning outcomes defined for their programme in the form of competences, learnings, knowledge and skills.

In my dissertation, I try to understand the students' challenges in the context of the increasing academisation of the social education programme – as well as the culture of perfection existing among students and as a general trend in contemporary society. The idea, formulated by student Jacob at the beginning of this article, that "it doesn't have to look right," can serve as a gateway to daring to participate in playful movement activities, even if it is difficult at first and several students describe it as a transgressive experience.

With one of the groups of students on the teacher education programme, I developed a reflection activity, which consisted of using plasticine in different colours to produce a choreographic map based on their experiences with the playful dance and movement activities. The students first spent almost an hour individually shaping different figures with their hands. For example, figures rep-

resenting the types of dance and body poses that they had previously been through with their bodies. Each student then presented their map, using the figures they had shaped to talk about the moods, feelings and challenges they had experienced. Referring to her figures on the choreographic map, Julie says:

It doesn't actually matter that the others are doing something completely different. The idea is to move around and have fun together. Jump into the unknown. Sometimes you have to remind yourself of that. At least I have to lots of times. You must dare to do something, even if it's not perfect (Julie, student on the social education programme, September 2021).

Julie's map testifies to the courage it takes to expand your repertoire of movement to include new and different ways of moving. When the students succeed in joining in the playful movements, the activity becomes about being together for the exact sake of being together and having fun. This is especially evident in the above-mentioned episodes with Rebecca and Sasha as playleaders. In these situations, the students do not stop to think about how they look, or whether the activity is aligned with the executive order and the learning outcomes defined for the programme. They let themselves be contaminated by their playful fellow students, simply because it looks fun, and they also want to have fun and be part of the activity.

The choreographic perspective

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Choreography originally meant the written recording or arranging dances. In my dissertation, I invite the reader to imagine the physical movements performed by a group of people as they move together spontaneously, with no script and without a detailed plan, like the recording of an instant choreography. The three episodes described are examples of how playful movements can be described from a choreographic perspective. The choreographic perspective focuses on the patterns of movement in the room.

With the exception of the third episode, where student Jonas breaks into markedly different movements, playful movements can often be hidden and difficult to register. The playful movements that are difficult to register can be seen as cracks in a carefully planned lesson plan or movement activity. These cracks can serve as gateways for adults as well as children to be creative and imperfect together. This does not change the fact that the social education programme in its present shape – along with many other places outside of the programme – is full of obstacles to being playful with one's body. But perhaps focusing on our movement patterns can help us to spot how an educational programme and a practice have the potential to change.

Final thoughts

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When social educators get up from their chairs, participate in children's play and are not afraid to move in playful ways, it rubs off on the surroundings. And opportunities are created for people to come together and form sensuous communities characterised by a sense of presence and without predetermined meaning or purpose. Communities where we allow ourselves to be overwhelmed by the unexpected – and communities where we experience something together rather than being distanced from each other. Therefore, being playful and dancing can be seen as part of the relational work of social educators.

Engaging in creative and playful movements requires courage in a world that often favours efficiency, documentation and performance. Moving in playful patterns can be seen as a form of resistance to unfree and ingrained ways of using one's body. It is therefore my hope that more educators, students and social educators will show the way by daring to dance and move in imperfect and imaginative ways. It is not about forcing anyone to participate, but rather about creating space for playful expressions of movement to unfold with different bodily styles and with room for diversity.

As an educator, have a go at introducing activities in your lessons during which the students are not allowed to say any words, but must express themselves using their bodies and sounds. As an educator and social educator, you can also try to frame activities that, in principle, can go on forever without any kind of endpoint. Finally, next time you see students or citizens doing something that may, on the face of it, seem bodily disturbing, you may want to leave your plan be and let yourself be moved by and marvel at the unexpected that can happen.

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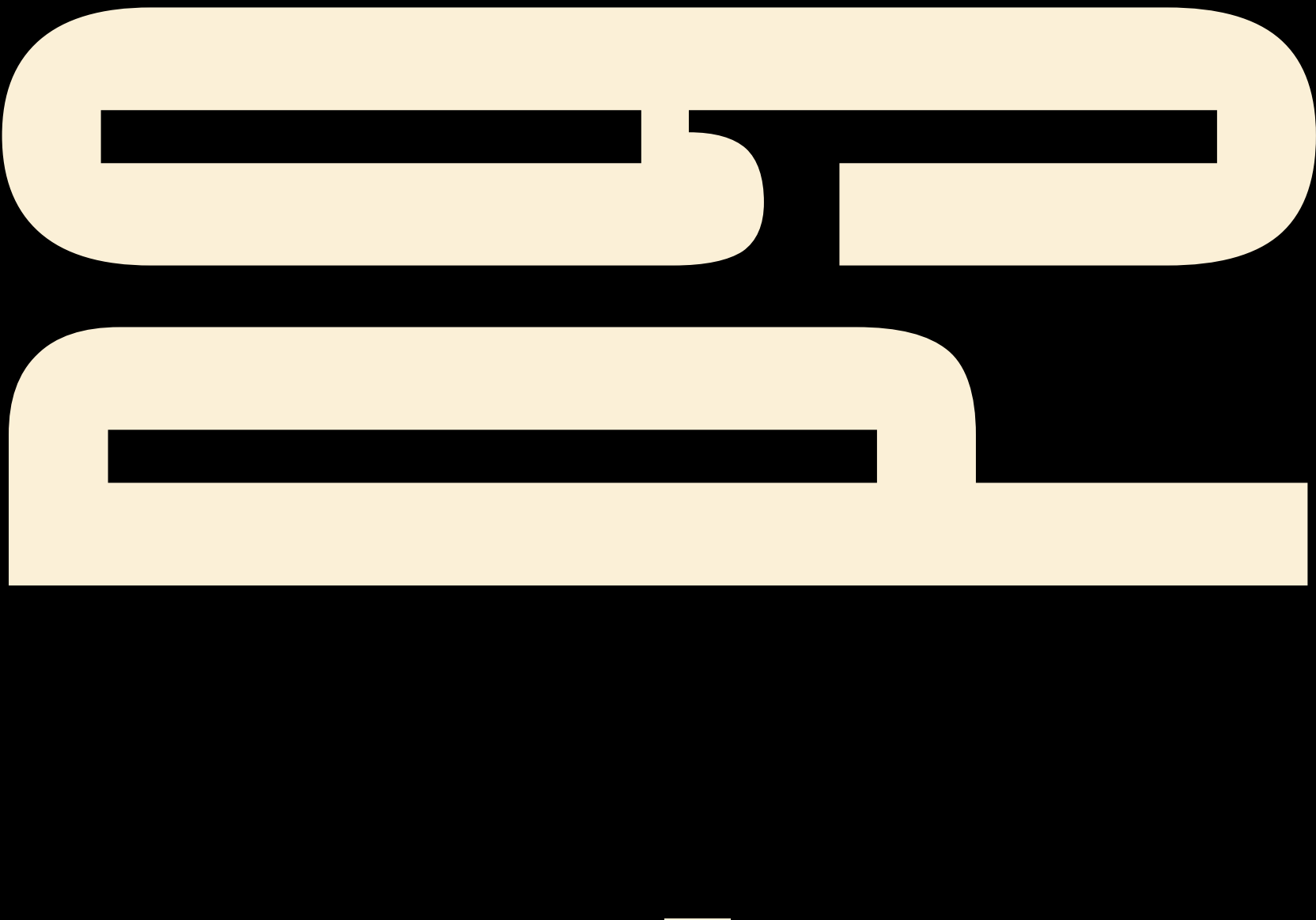
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FROM INTENDED LEARNING OUTCOMES TO LEARNING EXPERIENCE

– creating teaching centred around play

BY ANNE KRISTINE PETERSEN

Anne Kristine Petersen, Associate Professor and PhD student at University College Absalon. This article is based on Petersen's PhD project: Playful approaches to foreign language teaching - A design-based study of boundary crossing between design and educational practices in teacher education.

It is not easy for student teachers to plan teaching activities with playfulness in the foreground. This is shown by my PhD project, in which I have examined playful approaches to foreign language teaching. Here, student teachers have developed teaching designs based on playfulness as the key element. So how can we create opportunities for student teachers to design teaching activities with both great learning potential and play at the centre? In this article, I suggest how such a framework can be designed.

The developed framework is based on the assumption that when designing playful teaching activities, we need to shift our focus in the planning phase from:

- being based on intended learning outcomes to being centred around the pupil's *learning experience*
- planning teaching based on didactic categories to designing approaches to teaching based on *scenes*
- focusing on what pupils need to learn to exploring what they *can* learn through a given learning experience.

This shift not only opens up for a more exploratory approach to teaching but constitutes a necessary step towards realising the potential inherent in creating teaching based on playfulness.

Putting learning experience first

In my project, I have observed that both teacher educators and student teachers are strongly focused on designing teaching that targets specific outcomes within their subjects. And this makes sense because it contributes to targeted and structured teaching that meets the recommendations and requirements set out in the curriculum for the teacher education programmes and in the Common Objectives of the Folkeskole, respectively.

However, the strong focus on predefined learning outcomes acts as a stumbling block for many when it comes to designing playful teaching. The learning outcomes often end up largely dictating the teaching activities. There is consequently every reason to reassess the foundation on which we build when developing playful approaches to teaching. This was the conclusion drawn by a group of students having worked with developing playful didactic designs for a Year 5 class in English. One of the students put it this way:

We find ourselves thinking that perhaps we should focus more on what kind of experience we would like the pupils to have. Instead of focusing so much on the learning outcomes, we should perhaps look more at the experience we're trying to create... meaning the pupils' learning experience, or whatever you call it. It's like that's where we have to start if we are to do something they will

perceive as being playful. But is that okay? Starting by talking about what experience the pupils should have, and forgetting about the rest for a while, or what?

This quotation shows that there is a strong tradition on the teacher education programmes for teaching designs being dictated by learning outcomes. The tradition is so strong that the students feel they have to ask permission to do something else. The answer to the student's question is, of course, that: yes, they are welcome to start by discussing what learning experience they want to create. In fact, it is advisable to put the learning experience first when working with playful approaches to learning.

But what does it actually mean to put the learning experience first? My study shows that playful learning experiences are best created by using principles, theories or properties from the field of play as the starting point. In other words, playfulness must be seen as key to the process of developing playful teaching designs. This is important because it increases the probability that students and pupils will experience the didactic design as playful. At the same time, it gives us a lens through which teacher educators can conceptualise, discuss and qualify playfulness in their teaching.

This conceptualisation of playfulness is particularly important on teacher education programmes. It differs from most other study programmes in that you are teaching students who are themselves learning how to teach others. This calls for a double didactic perspective on the part of teacher educators – or second-order didactics. One way to operationalise second-order didactics is through modelling (Lunenberg et al., 2007), where the teacher educator explains and demonstrates specific practices, skills or concepts aimed at supporting student teachers in thinking and acting as competent teachers. In practice, this means that the teacher educator deliberately shows how an assignment or a process can be carried out, while the didactic considerations and the theoretical basis behind the educator's choice are also explained and discussed.

When working with playful approaches on teacher education programmes, it is therefore important to model didactic choices that relate to both subject-based learning and playfulness. My study shows that choices related to subject-based learning are often modelled, while playfulness rarely receives the same attention. This is a problem because it makes it more difficult to spot, discuss and qualify how playful approaches can be taken in different subjects, and how variation can be created in the way that playfulness is incorporated in specific subjects.

In my project, I have therefore, together with teacher educators and student teachers at University College Absalon, worked to develop a framework that – through principles and theory based on play or playfulness – puts playfulness at the centre of the design process. We have, for example, developed teaching designs based on *play types* and *play qualities*, while applying a learning perspective based on *forms of learning*.

A framework for playful learning experiences

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Play types refer to the archetypal ways in which children play. According to Hughes (2002), play can be divided into 16 different types, each of which has distinct characteristics and purposes. These types include role play, creative play, communication play and locomotor play. The play types are interesting

because they show the many different forms that play can take. They are thus well-suited for designing activities that can form the basis for interesting learning experiences. In the project, I have examined, together with teacher educators and student teachers, how different play types open up for different ways of using and working with foreign languages. We have also examined how playfulness is traditionally incorporated in language subjects, and how it can be incorporated in new ways through play types that are less frequently used in foreign languages but contain an exciting potential.

While play types are well-suited for framing the type of activity you want to create, we have used the concept of play qualities to understand and describe the special characteristics that arise in connection with playful teaching (Skovbjerg & Jørgensen, 2021). Different play types have different characteristics or qualities that you, as a didactician, can use when planning your teaching. The qualities of construction play are about assembling things, shaping materials based on an idea and experimenting with different types of materials. You typically sit down and work with others, while your hands control the process and decide what is to be built. Role play is characterised by completely different qualities. Here, the focus is on creating a story and taking on certain roles, depending on the play theme. In communication play, the qualities are focused on the exchange of ideas and information through language and body language – often with the aim of creating a joint narrative or performing an assignment together.

The concept of play qualities has been developed precisely for the purpose of enabling the clear conceptualisation of playfulness in the planning, realisation and evaluation of teaching. In my project, I have been concerned with examining how to design for specific play qualities in foreign language teaching, and how to make space for a wider range of play qualities within this disciplinary area.

When incorporating playfulness in our teaching in different ways, it affects the way we learn new things. In our efforts to develop playful approaches to foreign language teaching, we have therefore, in addition to focusing on play types and play qualities, looked at the British learning theorist Diana Laurillard's (2012) six learning types. These learning types, which form part of Laurillard's *Conversational Framework*, are based on a pupil-centred pedagogy and have been developed as a design tool for educators.

The six learning types start with *acquisition*, where the pupils gain new knowledge through activities such as reading and listening. This is followed by *inquiry/investigation*, which encourages the pupils to explore and discover for themselves through hands-on experiments or investigations. *Dialogue* or *discussion* is central, as this learning type creates space for questions and reflection. *Practice* gives the pupils the opportunity to test their knowledge and skills in specific situations, where they can learn through repetition and fine-tuning. *Production* involves the creation of a product or a result (for example, a presentation, a text or an artefact) that translates knowledge into practice. Finally, *collaboration* supports the pupils' learning through joint assignment performance and exchange of ideas.

In the project, I have examined how different play types and play qualities relate to the six learning types and the language learning

opportunities which arise through different combinations of play types, play qualities and learning types.

From summaries to scenes

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With the theoretical foundation in place – as a way of putting the learning experience first, we can now look at how it can be put into practice. A frequently used method for upholding didactic designs on teacher education programmes – in the planning phase – involves the use of different types of teaching plan templates. These templates contain classic didactic categories such as learning outcomes, objectives, activities, time frame and evaluation. Together, these categories constitute what I would call a *summary* of a teaching session. In other words, a summary provides an overview of the central teaching elements to a more or less detailed degree.

However, my project shows that if we want to capture the essence of playful learning experiences, we need to take a different approach. Classical didactic categories are, in fact, less suitable for capturing the special constituents of playful activities: the special mood, feeling, quality or properties that make the individual person experience the activity as playful. In my project, I have therefore worked with alternatives to summaries, drawing inspiration from the world of film and fiction in the form of *scenes*. Where a summary describes thought and action without dramatising it, scenes can be defined as a dramaturgical entity consisting of a perspective, a location and a time (VanderMeer, 2018). Fictional books are, for example, structured as a series of scenes linked by short summaries that drive the plot forward.

A scene typically depicts at least one actor in the present and the surroundings in which they find themselves. It may contain actions, moods and thoughts that are unfolding in the moment, making scenes particularly suitable for describing and disseminating experiences. In addition, scenes give didacticians the opportunity to visualise the playful learning experiences they want to create in their future teaching practice.

A scene that captures a playful didactic design should have a clear beginning and end, with the purpose of the beginning being to capture the recipient's attention. Make sure to include the necessary context, explain the location and interrelationships of the actors and choose a point of view.

A central element of a scene is tempo, which consists of rhythm and momentum. Rhythm is created by small cycles of cause and effect or stimulus and response, while momentum is about how rhythm builds up intensity and clarity. A well-balanced progression ensures that the scene does not end as an anticlimax.

If we now turn our attention to how playful learning experiences can be described and captured, my study shows that this is best done by following these steps:

1. Start by providing sufficient background information about the surroundings in which the scene takes place, who the key actors are and what relationship they have with each other.
2. Pay attention to capturing and creating a vibrant scene by describing the actions of the actors and the mood serving as a backdrop to the scene.
3. Think of the progression of the scene in small cycles of cause and effect and try

arranging these so that you alternately build up intensity and clarification.

4. Make sure to end the scene in a way that makes it feel rounded to the reader.

While the above applies to scenes in general, whether they take place in or outside class, the following applies to scenes that describe playful learning experiences in the classroom:

5. Choose a subject-specific theme or topic for which you want to create a playful learning experience.
6. Look into the learning potential associated with different play types in relation to the chosen theme. Choose a play type with a particularly large or unexplored learning potential in relation to the subject-related content.
7. Decide which play quality(ies) you want to design for. Let the chosen play qualities take centre stage in the scene through the language you use.
8. Consider what learning type you want the students or pupils to work with, and how this learning type can support the chosen play qualities.

Steps 5-8 thus aim at exploring combinations of subject-related content, play types, play qualities and learning types, the purpose being to examine the possible learning potentials of specific didactic designs.

A playful learning experience can be illustrated by an example from my project, where, as previously mentioned, a group of student teachers developed didactic designs for a Year 5 class in English. With inspiration from storytelling, the pupils were given the assignment of creating their own superhero or superheroine who had to solve a specific challenge: saving their hometown from being destroyed by a bomb. In this process, the students became aware that playful learning experiences are best supported when the teacher also adopts a playful attitude. Therefore, they worked hard to incorporate a playful teacher role in their didactic design. In the following, their plan is described through a scene:

The classroom is completely quiet and dark, only the dim light from some small lamps creates faint shadows on the walls. The pupils are waiting excitedly, some looking at each other, while two girls try to hold back a giggle. Suddenly, the door is flung open, and a man wearing a black cape and mask makes a dramatic entrance. Without hesitation, he strides to the centre of the classroom. He jumps up onto an empty table, raises himself on his toes and reaches towards the lamp hanging from the ceiling. He places a small, round object on the lamp which immediately catches everyone's attention.

"No one can stop this bomb. It will explode at sunrise, and the city will be mine!" he exclaims with a grim laughter as he looks around without paying much attention to the 24 gaping pupils sitting around him. A heavy silence falls on the room as he stands there like a shadow. Without a word, he jumps down from the table, his cloak flapping dramatically around him as he disappears out the door. The pupils are left speechless, looking at each other with a mixture of wonder and excitement.

The scene shows how a situation can be described very concisely to serve a guideline for what a teaching session based on a playful approach can look like. The context is briefly sketched: a classroom with dim lighting (*context*). There is an excited atmosphere among the pupils, who constitute one group of actors in the scene. The other actor is the mysterious cloaked man (*the teacher*), who drives the

action forward through a series of actions. He enters dramatically, moves quickly, jumps up onto a table, places a bomb, laughs grimly and exits again dramatically (*play qualities*). Although the teacher is the most active actor in the scene, the pupils are just as much part of the role play (*play type*). They are the ones tasked with stopping the villain. The dramatic opening scene helps frame the pupils' work and acts in the storytelling process as their acquisition (*learning type*) of the problem they are facing.

With this scene as the pivot for their planning, the student teachers developed a teaching programme on narrative genres and vocabulary linked to character traits, appearance and abilities (*subject-based content*) which incorporated different play types (especially *role play*) as well as play qualities and learning types.

From what students need to learn, to what they can learn

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When we start imagining scenes for playful learning experiences in the planning phase, the subject-specific learning outcomes slip more into the background. This does not mean that the pupils no longer need to learn anything. However, it means that the teacher has less control of what the pupils learn. Instead, as teachers, we must pay attention to the environment we create for the pupils' learning and what opportunities it offers. Such a shift can draw theoretic inspiration from the concept of *affordances*. The theory of affordances (Gibson, 1979) describes the opportunities for action offered by a given environment for those who are in it. It is about how the surroundings can invite certain types of interactions or activities – for example how a chair encourages you to sit down, or an open space invites movement and exploration. In a teaching context, this means that in the design of the teaching, the focus should be on the potential learning opportunities offered by a given learning experience. In a playful learning experience, it is therefore not sufficient to steer the teaching towards specific learning outcomes; instead, the didactic design should highlight the open opportunities for action that make it possible for the pupils themselves to experiment with the subject-specific content and create meaning. A situation in which the pupils' environment is, for example, characterised by not only a teacher but also a cloaked villain with a bomb expands the pupils' opportunities for action, because the classic teacher-pupil relationship is set aside, creating space for new dynamics and interactions.

With an affordance-based approach, we have now come full circle around the shift in perspective I mentioned by way of introduction. The shift entails a number of alternatives to the questions that student teachers traditionally ask themselves when planning a teaching session, such as "what learning outcomes do I want my pupils to achieve today?" Instead, other questions arise:

- How do I create a playful learning experience?
- What play type could be of interest, given this particular subject-specific theme?
- How do I create an environment characterised by diverse and unpredictable learning opportunities for my class?

Final thoughts

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My study shows how the planning of teaching activities based on a playful approach calls for

a shift in perspective. It is first and foremost about putting the pupils' learning experience centre stage. A playful learning experience can be described through scenes consisting of a context, a mood, a number of actors and the actions that they perform. The actors' actions are linked to play qualities and learning types, and the context is incorporated as an affordance-rich environment that can inspire the actors to take new and unforeseen paths.

Making such a shift is not simple. Imagining scenes that take all of these factors into account takes practice and getting used to. However, my research indicates that such a shift is necessary in order to fully realise the potential of playful approaches to learning.

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P10

THE POWER OF AFFECT

– designing inclusive, playful learning experiences

BY JENNIFER ANN SKRIVER

Jennifer Ann Skriver, Postdoc and PhD at Kolding School of Design. This article is based on Skriver's PhD project: Advancing Inclusive Playful Learning Practices: Critical Examination of Affective and Embodied Dynamics in Artful Educational Practices as Catalysts for Playful Learning. The article is originally written in English.

In contemporary education, particularly within playful learning contexts, the role of affect – the dynamics of emotions, embodied interactions, and how they unfold within educational environments – has been increasingly recognized as fundamental. All pedagogy is inherently affective, and understanding this is crucial for educators aiming to create inclusive and transformative learning experiences. However, the backdrop against which playful learning is developed, particularly in Nordic countries, presents both opportunities and challenges. While these societies are often celebrated for their commitment to equality, structural inequities persist. Marginalization based on race, ethnicity, gender, disability, socioeconomic status, and other intersecting identities continues to shape how a sense of belonging/alienation is experienced in educational spaces.

This article explores how educators at the social education programmes can harness the power of affect to design playful learning encounters that foster belonging, creativity, and engagement for all students. Drawing on insights from my dissertation (Skriver, 2024a) and related scholarly work, I emphasize the importance of addressing how intersecting systems of privilege and exclusion operate within educational settings. These dynamics often shape the affective experiences of individuals with marginalized identities and underscore the need for intentional and inclusive design of playful learning environments.

Affect as the Foundation of Pedagogy

Understanding that all pedagogy is affective highlights teaching and learning as inherently relational, emotional, and embodied processes. Educational spaces are not neutral; they are charged with emotions and power dynamics shaped by historical and social contexts (Ahmed, 2014). Affect refers to these relational forces that bind individuals together, influencing their behaviors, experiences, and sense of self. This understanding is crucial for educators designing playful learning experiences, because affect is not just an emotional state but a dynamic, ongoing process that shapes every pedagogical encounter. Playful learning depends on these affective dimensions, the aim being to create spaces where students can explore, create, and collaborate in ways that engage their whole selves. However, affect is not uniformly experienced. BIPOC individuals (Black, Indigenous and People of Color), women and nonbinary students, LGBTQ+ students, those with disabilities, and those from lower socioeconomic backgrounds may face challenges in playful learning spaces where unmarked norms and assumptions about belonging can operate as barriers.

In Nordic countries, these unmarked norms often align with broader myths of equality and neutrality that can obscure systemic inequities (Wekker, 2016). While Nordic societies are frequently positioned as models of equity, critical scholars argue that assumptions of neutrality often erase the lived realities of marginalized groups. These assumptions extend to education, where playful learning spaces are sometimes designed without considering the structural barriers that shape student experience. For instance, playful activities requiring physical mobility may unintentionally exclude students with disabilities, while socioeconomic barriers can limit access to certain materials or experiences.

Recognizing that all pedagogy is affective allows educators to move beyond cognitive models of learning, which often fail to account for the diverse emotional and bodily experiences of students. Instead, such recognition foregrounds the importance of designing playful learning environments where these diverse affective experiences are recognized, supported, and valued. This recognition forms the basis of inclusive education and is integral to fostering environments where all students can thrive (Skriver, 2024a).

Hauntology and the Persistence of Inequities

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Hauntology provides a powerful lens for understanding how historical injustices – whether rooted in colonialism, patriarchy, ableism, classism, or other systems of oppression – continue to influence present-day educational spaces. The concept of hauntology, as developed by Jacques Derrida (1994), invites us to confront "ghosts" of the past that linger in the present and shape future possibilities. These specters of inequity are not merely historical remnants, but active forces that manifest in the social, emotional, and material dynamics of learning environments. In playful learning spaces, the ghosts of exclusionary practices and systemic inequities are often felt but not seen, and shape feelings of belonging or alienation (Skriver, 2023). For example, the legacy of colonial education systems can "haunt" classrooms by perpetuating norms and practices that prioritize dominant cultural values, often to the detriment of students from marginalized racial, ethnic, or cultural backgrounds. Similarly, ableist frameworks can linger in the design of playful activities that fail to consider the needs of students with disabilities, creating barriers to full participation.

These "ghostly matters" as Avery Gordon (2008) describes them, are most insidious when they go unacknowledged. In Nordic contexts, the widespread myth of equality and neutrality often obscures the continued influence of historical inequities. While Nordic societies are often portrayed as egalitarian, structural inequities tied to race, gender, and class persist. The denial of these inequities can reinforce exclusionary practices in education because the affective dynamics of classrooms remain shaped by histories that privilege certain identities over others (Skriver, 2023). Recognizing the hauntological presence of these inequities allows educators to confront how past systems of exclusion continue to exert affective force in learning environments. These forces are not abstract; they are felt in instances of exclusion, such as when students' unique perspectives or needs are overlooked, leading to feelings of discomfort, frustration, or isolation.

Krueger's (2021) work on atmospheres underscores that spaces are never neutral; they are imbued with histories, power relations, and collective emotions. In this sense, playful learning spaces are charged atmospheres where the specters of exclusion shape who feels included and who does not.

Addressing these dynamics requires educators to engage in "ghost hunting" – the identification and dismantling of the invisible forces that perpetuate inequities. By acknowledging and addressing the hauntological dynamics of inequity, educators can begin to design playful learning environments that actively counteract these ghosts (Skriver, 2023). This involves creating spaces where all students –regardless of their identities or backgrounds – feel seen, valued, and empowered to participate. Through this process, the grip the past has on the present can be loosened to enable creation of truly inclusive and transformative educational spaces.

Creating Inclusive Affective Arrangements and Designing Inclusive Atmospheres

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To design playful learning experiences that are truly inclusive, educators must prioritize creating intentional "affective arrangements" (Slaby et al., 2019) and cultivate inclusive atmospheres that embrace the diversity of students' identities and experiences. These arrangements go beyond the physical setup of the classroom to encompass:

- *The social environment:* By fostering collective emotional engagement, interactions are dynamically co-shaped, creating an affective arrangement that cultivates a unified, empathetic community.
- *The structure of activities:* By ensuring that the affective structure of the learning environment supports equitable participation, all students are enabled to engage meaningfully and fully.
- *The ways in which educators interact with students:* By aligning educational practices with students' affective experiences, educators can foster trust and respect, strengthening emotional and relational dynamics in the learning environment.
- *The overall emotional tone of the space:* By actively managing and guiding the space's emotional tone, educators can ensure that it promotes safety, creativity, and inclusivity, while fostering constructive and equitable interactions.

In my dissertation, I argue that inclusive, playful learning environments must also be designed with sensitivity to the diverse affective histories students bring – histories shaped by cultural backgrounds, gender identities, socioeconomic circumstances, physical abilities, and past experiences of inclusion or exclusion (Skriver, 2024a). For BIPOC students, these histories often involve encounters with marginalization and discrimination, which can shape how they engage with playful learning contexts and influence their emotional responses and sense of agency. My research highlights the importance of intentionally fostering "atmospheres of inclusion" that promote belonging and interconnectedness among all students (ibid.). These inclusive atmospheres create "we spaces" (Krueger, 2011; 2021) where students feel part of a collective, engaged community and are empowered to participate fully and authentically.

Creating inclusive spaces requires more than adjusting the physical environment;

it also requires a thoughtful reshaping of the social and cultural dynamics that shape student interactions. To foster truly inclusive atmospheres, educators must be deeply attuned to the affective dynamics within their classrooms. This involves recognizing the diverse emotional and cultural histories students bring with them and adapting the learning atmosphere to accommodate their varied needs and experiences. By cultivating "we spaces" educators intentionally promote authentic belonging, allowing students to express their identities freely and without pressure to conform to dominant or supposedly neutral norms. Such a deliberate approach ensures that all students, particularly those from marginalized backgrounds, feel acknowledged, valued, and secure, and empowers them to engage fully and meaningfully in the learning process (Skriver, 2024b).

Navigating Affective Resonance and Dissonance

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Affect, as relational and dynamic, has the power to unify or divide, include or exclude (Ahmed, 2014). While playful learning encounters often aim to generate affective resonance – a state where emotions and interactions harmonize, creating a collective sense of connection – they can also lead to affective dissonance when students do not feel welcomed or validated in these spaces. Curiosity toward moments of dissonance is essential because it allows both educators and students to approach these experiences as opportunities for reflection and dialogue (Skriver & Jensen, 2024).

For instance, in my research, a Danish student shared how she initially found improvisational exercises intimidating but eventually discovered that they helped her "open up" and engage with peers. She described how the group dynamic – infused with silliness and the breaking of personal boundaries, such as sticking out tongues and attempting headstands – fostered a sense of shared playfulness. This environment enabled her to connect with others and contribute creatively to tasks like designing posters. These co-created, low-pressure interactions demonstrate how affective resonance can emerge, encouraging collective engagement and creativity (Skriver & Jensen, 2024; Skriver, 2024b).

In contrast, a Kurdish student expressed the challenges of navigating cultural and personal boundaries in the same setting. Despite her openness and willingness to participate, she noted the difficulties of feeling aligned with her Danish peers. She explained how racialized narratives influenced her interactions, describing moments of hesitation and self-consciousness when choosing a partner or participating fully in exercises. Her reflections highlighted the affective dissonance she experienced, because cultural differences and fear of misperception shaped her affective engagement (Skriver & Jensen, 2024).

These examples illustrate the dual nature of affective dynamics: while resonance fosters inclusion and belonging, dissonance reveals the exclusions and tensions that marginalized students often experience. For the Danish student, the playful learning environment facilitated personal growth and group cohesion, demonstrating the potential of affective resonance to create meaningful connections. Yet for the Kurdish student, dissonance exposed how implicit norms within these spaces can privilege certain ways of being or knowing over others, reinforcing feelings of exclusion.

To navigate these dynamics effectively, educators must approach dissonance not as a failure but as a critical moment for learning and transformation. Recognizing the historical and social power structures that shape individual experiences is vital. Curiosity can guide educators to explore how norms, practices, and expectations affect students differently, thus enabling the former to design activities and interactions that accommodate diverse modes of participation. By intentionally creating inclusive spaces that validate the varied emotional and cultural expressions students bring, educators can foster affective resonance while addressing and mitigating dissonance. In doing so, playful learning environments can become spaces where all students feel seen, valued, and connected.

Power Dynamics and Affect in Playful Learning

All pedagogy is inherently affective, shaped by broader social, cultural, and political dynamics that influence who feels comfortable and included. Playful learning spaces, while aiming to foster connection and creativity, can inadvertently reinforce existing power structures. For instance, students whose identities align with dominant norms often find these environments affirming, while marginalized students may experience discomfort or alienation due to implicit expectations embedded in activities. My research highlights how these dynamics manifest in contrasting student experiences. Some students described playful exercises as intuitive and engaging, while others, particularly those from underrepresented cultural or socio-economic backgrounds, struggled to connect. Activities such as collaborative projects or improvisational tasks often revealed subtle misalignments between the norms of the space and the diverse ways students approached learning, creating barriers to full participation.

To foster truly inclusive, playful learning environments, educators must address these power dynamics by designing activities that accommodate multiple ways of engaging. Arts-based approaches, such as storytelling, improvisation, or collaborative creation in visual or performing arts, offer students diverse and flexible pathways to engage that allow them to draw on their personal strengths and unique perspectives. Staying responsive to students' feedback and adapting practices in real time ensures that the learning space evolves to meet diverse needs. By actively challenging exclusionary norms and fostering inclusive practices, educators can create playful learning environments where all students feel seen, valued, and empowered. These spaces can transcend reproducing dominant structures, becoming places of genuine equity, belonging, and transformative learning (Skriver, 2024b).

Scaffolding Affective Engagement

Designing inclusive, playful learning environments requires intentional scaffolding of affective engagement, which supports students as they transition from states of uncertainty or hesitation to openness, confidence, and connection. This process involves creating activities and spaces that engage students emotionally, physically, and socially, encouraging them to move beyond familiar ways of interacting and participating.

Effective scaffolding often begins with low-pressure activities that foster trust and comfort and gradually builds toward more

complex and collaborative interactions. Educators play a key role by setting a welcoming tone and guiding students to engage meaningfully with one another. This approach helps students overcome initial reluctance and fosters a shared sense of connection and creativity (Skriver & Jensen, 2024).

For instance, starting with a simple, low-stakes activity that encourages students to share something about themselves or express an idea in a nonverbal or creative way can help establish a foundation of trust. Activities that emphasize participation without fear of judgment – such as small group discussions, collaborative brainstorming, or lighthearted icebreakers – can reduce anxiety and make students feel more comfortable engaging with peers. By incorporating these low-pressure interactions, educators can create a supportive environment that builds confidence and encourages students to step into more complex and collaborative tasks over time. This gradual progression helps foster an inclusive atmosphere where all students feel welcomed and valued. Scaffolding also requires real-time responsiveness, where educators adjust their practices to meet the evolving needs of students. Encouraging techniques such as affirming contributions and emphasizing collaboration can help build positive dynamics and a sense of inclusion within the group. When educators foster an environment of mutual respect and curiosity, students are more likely to engage fully and authentically.

Additionally, scaffolding must account for the diverse emotional and cultural histories students bring into the space. Recognizing and adapting to these varied experiences helps ensure that all participants feel valued and supported. Creating inclusive atmospheres requires educators to acknowledge past challenges students may have faced and provide opportunities for new and affirming experiences that validate their identities. By emphasizing relational engagement, minimizing hierarchies, and encouraging participation at all levels, scaffolding becomes a tool not just for facilitating activities but for fostering transformation. Scaffolding creates opportunities for students to feel empowered, valued, and connected, enabling playful learning to be a truly inclusive and enriching experience for everyone.

Conclusion

Affect is the connective tissue of pedagogy, shaping the ways students engage, learn, and build relationships within educational spaces. This dynamic, embodied, and emotional force holds tremendous potential for fostering inclusion, belonging, and creativity—particularly within playful learning environments. However, as this article has highlighted, affect also reveals the structural inequities that persist in education, especially when dominant norms and unmarked assumptions limit the participation and recognition of marginalized students.

In Nordic educational contexts, the challenge lies in addressing the myths of equality, neutrality and post-raciality, which often obscure ongoing systems of exclusion and privilege. Recognizing these dynamics requires educators to engage with the histories, power structures, and emotional landscapes that shape their pedagogical practices. By embracing intentionality and curiosity, educators can "hunt ghosts" of inequity and confront and dismantle the hidden forces that alienate some students while affirming others.

Through designing inclusive affective arrangements and scaffolding engagement, educators can transform playful learning spaces into sites of genuine belonging and empowerment. This process demands a commitment to validating diverse affective histories, fostering "we spaces" where students feel seen and valued, and co-creating atmospheres that challenge exclusionary norms. These efforts are not simply about broadening access but also about reimagining education as a relational, transformative experience for all participants.

By centering affect and intentionally addressing systems of privilege and exclusion, educators can make playful learning a tool for equity, creativity, and empowerment. The stakes are high, but the potential is profound: the creation of playful educational spaces where all students can thrive and where learning becomes a shared journey of connection and possibility.

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Pt1

MY APPROACH IS NOT ALL THAT PLAYFUL—I'M MORE OF A TRADITIONAL TEACHER

BY LISE HOSTRUP SØNNICHSEN

Lise Hostrup Sønnichsen, Associate Professor and PhD at University College South Denmark at the research programme Pædagogik og pædagogisk praksis. This article is based on Sønnichsen's PhD project: At bevæge og blive bevæget - En undersøgelse af legende tilgange i læreruddannelsen og forbindelser til professionsdannelse. (To Move and Be Moved – An Exploration of Playful Approaches in Teacher Education and Their Connections to Professional Development).

This article is about the teacher educator as a playful role model as well as connections between student teachers' professional development (*Bildung*) and their participation in study activities characterised by playful approaches. In the article, I focus on the teacher educator's importance for such connections, which emerged as a recurring theme in the empirical data collected as part of my PhD project on one of University College South Denmark's teacher education programmes in the years 2020-2023.

Professional development (*Bildung*) should be understood as the type of formation that is reflected in the way in which professionals think about and go about their work (Hammershøj, 2017). The analyses in my thesis show that student teachers' participation in study activities characterised by playful approaches stimulates their understanding of:

1. teaching methods and themselves as designers of teaching activities
2. themselves as disseminators of bodily playful teaching activities
3. differentiation and variation in teaching activities
4. children in teaching contexts and thus traditional teaching in existing practice.

In this article, I will focus on the first two results, as this is where the connection between the teacher educator as a role model and the students' professional development is most evident. I exemplify this based on a single student's story – Aisha's story. As an introduction to this, I will briefly discuss the empirical data of my thesis and the understanding of the purpose – of creating designs for study activities characterised by playful approaches – that provided the foundation for the project. I will also elaborate on the understanding of professional development (*Bildung*) that has influenced my analysis and the results.

Small stories

The primary empirical data in the project consisted of 'small stories'. They can be understood as identity work that emerges as fragments of experience, narrated based on an incentive to share, test, respond or influence something in dialogue with others (Bamberg, 2011). In my PhD thesis, I have used a narrative method (Bamberg & Georgakopoulou, 2008) to analyse small stories in which students talk about or discuss their participation in study activities with each other and with me or their educator.

Most of the small stories were collected during pedagogical everyday practice in the period both before and after the students' internship. This made it analytically possible to gain an insight into the connection between the students' participation in teaching activ-

ities characterised by playful approaches on campus and their self-initiated participation in playful knowledge dissemination during their internship.

With Dewey as driving force

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The small stories were collected among students who were taught by an experienced associate professor in English. This associate professor was, together with me, interested in exploring how playful approaches could be designed and make sense in a school subject. In the project, playful approaches were understood as a variation of 'borrowed' forms of practice associated with play in other contexts (Sicart, 2017). Such practices include, for example, movement games and aesthetic forms of expression such as dancing, singing, storytelling, role-playing and construction play using – in the context – atypical materials. On the basis of these forms of practice and a problem-based approach, we designed activities aimed at promoting a playful attitude in the students.

The goal was to challenge the students' habits in ways that forced them to use their judgment and creativity in an experimental process and combine different elements in new ways – concretely, physically and mentally. A playful attitude can be characterised as a goal-oriented process that is spurred on by a challenge, a problem or an assignment that you do not immediately know how to solve. The theoretical springboard was John Dewey's understanding of the playful attitude as something that has the potential to turn work into art (Dewey 2006, 222).

The students' professional development process

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Our interest in the connection between playful approaches and the students' professional development process first arose based on empirical data and analysis. On this basis, Lars G. Hammershøj's (2017) concept of professional *Bildung* and professional *Bildung* types – creativity, judgment and willingness – were chosen as the interpretive framework. Professional *Bildung* relates to the willingness to work and remain open, creative and innovative in the effort to solve the challenges that inevitably arise in modern working life (Hammershøj, 2017).

In a primary school and lower secondary school context, pedagogical/didactic challenges will naturally arise, and they call precisely for creativity, willingness and judgment in teachers. Teachers are subject to a purpose that is about "developing working methods and creating such opportunities for experience, absorption and industry that the pupils develop their awareness and imagination as well as confidence in their own possibilities and a background for committing themselves and taking action" (BUVM, 2024: *Bekendtgørelse af lov om folkeskolen* (Act to consolidate the Danish Folkeskole Act), Section 1(2)). From a professional development perspective, an English teacher will, for example, be concerned with developing frameworks and methods that create a fertile soil for pupils to dare and be willing to engage in communication in English. This entails a risk of failure and an opportunity for liberation presented by the ability to communicate in and understand a world language in a globalised world (Læreruddannelsens Ledernetværk, 2018, p. 11).

In the project, professional development processes were understood as social processes characterised by personal transformation. This means processes in which socialised ways of acting are challenged, and you come into conflict with yourself, eventually leading to self-reunification. Professional development processes are usually spurred by something. Something triggering so-called life feelings of disgust or longing. Feelings that can also be associated with a feeling of failure and a longing to be able to act differently. A development process requires personal freedom of action and occurs, for example, through imitation, or when you let yourself be inspired by role models in the process of forming your own taste (Hammershøj, 2017).

Analytically, professional development (*Bildung*) processes can be related to phases of opening, transcendence, the formation of experience and reflection (Hammershøj, 2017 – with reference to Immanuel Kant, 1784). In the following, I will highlight how these phases are represented in Aisha's story. The exemplification has been adjusted to suit the purpose of this article without being representative of my PhD thesis analyses. Readers who want insight into the full analyses can find my thesis at UC Viden (Sønnichsen, 2024).

Aisha's story

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Retrospectively, Aisha described how it had almost been a shock to return to class as a Year 4 student after a leave of absence. She found herself stepping into a teaching form that was completely different to the one she was used to. She had especially felt challenged by study activities where she had to put herself on the line and into play physically, for example by expressing herself aesthetically through dance and song:

A lot of the time I was just sitting there, watching the others. I also used to think: "How come they [her fellow students] can join in, but I can't?" (extract from conversation with Aisha, April 3rd 2023).

In the quotation below, which dates from the year before the above quotation, Aisha in fact rejects the idea of using a playful approach in her future role as a teacher:

Well, my approach is not all that playful, I don't feel so creative about it (...) *I'm more of a traditional teacher* (...) *kind of bookish, where the pupils sit at their desks* (Aisha, April 24th 2022).

Both quotations show how working with playful approaches has aroused so-called life feelings in Aisha. In the quotation from 2022, disgust is expressed in Aisha's positioning of herself as a traditional teacher and thus indirectly as someone who is in opposition to being a teacher with a playful approach: "My approach is not all that playful (...) I'm more of a traditional teacher."

In the retrospective reflection – the quotation from 2023 – there is also a longing to be able to engage fully and thus an experience of inadequacy: "How come they [her fellow students] can join in, but I can't?"

In general, the part of Aisha's story that was collected after her internship is linked to the fourth phase of the professional development process, where reflection is key. Here, Aisha works retrospectively to put her experience into words (Hammershøj, 2017). It is through this retrospective reflective phase that it becomes possible to say something about the other phases of her professional development process.

The first actual phase in a professional development process is the *opening phase*.

It is represented in the following quotation, where Aisha describes how she experienced her pupils' lack of motivation in the 'traditional' teaching situation that she had planned during her internship. Again, she is confronted with the feeling of inadequacy associated with a longing to be able to motivate her pupils. The quotation also says something about how, through this confrontation, Aisha begins to take a critical view of the 'traditional' teaching methods with which she had previously identified. From a formative perspective, she has not yet transcended her old way of thinking, but she is describing how an awareness of possibilities arose:

Well, I recall the time (...), where we talked about our willingness to use Playful Learning in our teaching. And I was like, "well, I'm more into traditional teaching" and so on. And then during my third internship (...) They [the pupils] were simply so demotivating. At first, they were kind of interested, perhaps because of the novelty factor of me being a new teacher, but, after the second time, I realised that "I'll have to do something" (...) I thought: "What would she [the teacher educator] do now?" Well, she thinks outside the box a lot (...) How would she plan her teaching in a way that would engage most of the pupils?

The quotation shows how the teacher educator as a role model functions both as a kind of 'anchor' and as an 'engine' for the next phase in Aisha's professional development process, which is the transcendence phase.

Signs of the transcendence phase in a *Bildung* process can be reflected in enthusiasm for what happens when habitual ways of doing things are suspended (Hammershøj, 2017). The following statements show how, 'spurred' by her confrontation with the pupils' lack of motivation and encouraged by her educator's experimental style, Aisha seems to have found the courage to open up to what she describes as her own creativity. Through this, she has gained experiences that have influenced her understanding of herself as a designer of teaching activities. The following part of my conversation with her illustrates this:

I like cut-and-glue activities, for example. I like being creative. I like to paint, I like many things, but I didn't know at first how to make it, you know, part of my teaching (...)

I was rushing around (...) And I kept thinking about what Elena [synonym for the teacher educator] was like. In fact, she was constantly on my mind, and I thought: "What would Elena have done?" Well, and I actually didn't think that it was so hard to do, and, yes, it was a nice feeling (...)

I feel that it [observing] has changed me, that I have absorbed it (...) I don't understand why at all, but when I had passed English and started my internship, I don't know what happened [she laughs so much that she makes me laugh too]. Well, then it all came together, and Elena's way of teaching suddenly made sense to me, and why we had to do all these things. I was able to apply some of the things we had been through, and it makes a difference that you've been through it yourself, it makes it easier to pass it on to others.

Lise: *So what you're saying is that you've been through a process?*

Aisha: *Yes, bodily (...) Yes, because, during my internship, there were pupils who did not really dare to participate in the activities I had planned. But when I joined in myself, well, it motivated them, I mean they could see me as a reflection of themselves in a way (...) So that, afterwards, they thought it had been great fun. And my creativity then started flowing when I was planning classes and getting things ready (Aisha, April 3rd 2023).*

Aisha tells me how, when preparing her classes, she started creating her own materi-

als with scissors and glue. She also mentions that she enjoys and has experience with being creative and using her hands to create things. From a professional development perspective, you can say that – by creatively combining the joyful experiences of being creative with her hands with her competences as an English teacher – Aisha has opened up new possibilities in her professional practice. Her experience of succeeding as a teacher on this basis can be said to contribute to her potentially developing a taste for adopting a playful attitude to the work of preparing and designing classes and teaching materials.

In the quotation, Aisha also talks about the changes that have happened to the way she uses her own body in the teaching situation. Taking inspiration from – or perhaps even imitating – the teacher educator's bodily playful teaching style, Aisha has a feeling of succeeding in motivating her pupils: "I was rushing around (...) And I kept thinking about what Elena [synonym for the teacher educator] was like." Among other things, Aisha feels that she is able to engage the students who lack the courage to participate in the English classes. She believes that her own experiences from the classes taught by the teacher educator play a role. From a professional development perspective, it would seem that her own experience of inadequacy, disgust and longing – when it comes to participating in teaching activities characterised by a playful approach – has influenced her understanding of and approach to bodily leadership. In this way, you can help pupils overcome their reservations: "It makes a difference that you've been through it yourself if you're to be able to pass it on to others."

The above story exemplifies the third phase of the professional development process, which is the *experience phase*. Aisha feels that her new approach has a bearing on her ability to 'find her own identity' as a teacher, and this becomes crucial for her being able to critically assess her former conduct. The story draws a connection between Aisha's own participation in study activities characterised by playful approaches and changes to her understanding of herself as *a bodily playful disseminator, classroom leader and creative designer of teaching activities.* Aisha has undergone a development – from an approach based on the view that: "I know I'll never be like that; it just isn't me" to an approach based on the view that: "But when I joined in myself, well, it motivated them, I mean they could see me as a reflection of themselves in a way." And from the story: "My approach is not all that playful; I don't feel so creative," to the story: "I like being creative (...) And I actually didn't think that it was all that difficult (...)"

The teacher educator as a playful and experimental role model

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As humans, we can be formed in someone else's image (Hammershøj, 2017), and research has shown that teachers tend to teach in the same way as they themselves have been taught. Seen in this light, the teacher educator's importance as a role model is not surprising. But what made this particular teacher educator a playful role model?

In my thesis, I describe the educator as someone who generally aligns with the ideas of what constitutes good teaching practices presented in the research literature. Educators can be characterised by engagement, high expectations of students, clarification of the structuring of space, time and progression in relation to learning objectives, focus on

feedback, relationship work and alignment of expectations. In this way, my thesis reflects what playful approaches have to offer to such teacher educators and, through this, to their students.

At the beginning of the project, the teacher educator's teaching practices already comprised certain playful elements in a controlled form. Something she herself described as "drops of playfulness". What happened was that, during the experimental process, she herself entered a kind of professional development process focused on developing her own practice while at the same time challenging her own willingness, creativity and judgment. In her own words, when she first "adopted a playful approach", she began to draw on a playful experimental repertoire that was unknown to me and combined it creatively with goals for her subject. In this way, playfulness authentically gained both depth and subject-related relevance. "The drops of playfulness" increased in number, and a greater degree of unpredictability, process and uncertainty became part of her educational design. In her classes, her students were given the chance to experience playful subject-specific didactics on their own bodies. They also had the chance to experience how an experimental and playful role model with a playful attitude works.

The teacher educator told the students that she was experimenting and provided both implicit and explicit insights into her ideas and her enthusiasm when succeeding. She also provided insights into her uncertainty and awareness of the risk involved in experimenting. By leading the way with a playful attitude, characterised by playing with roles, rules and frameworks (Sutton-Smith, 2001), she implicitly raised the students' awareness that high academic standards, good classroom management and a playful attitude are not necessarily incompatible elements.

The power of stories

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The analysis in my thesis shows how participating in teaching activities characterised by playful approaches can awaken life feelings of disgust and longing. It also shows how students can get the feeling of succeeding as teachers during their internship by working with children's motivation through their own playful approaches. At the same time, it shows how the teacher educator as a playful, experimental role model can have a bearing on the students' ability to overcome their own inhibitions and participate at their own initiative in playful knowledge dissemination during their internship.

My recommendation is therefore that teacher educators who – through willingness, creativity and judgment – strive on a daily basis to turn teaching into art by adopting a playful approach, take an interest in the development of students' small stories over time. The stories can offer an insight into the importance of the teacher educator's own invisible presence to students' professional development process. This may have a bearing on their willingness to maintain a playful approach and attitude in their teaching.

Stories have power. They are made of air, but they leave their mark (Frank, 2010, 43).

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WHERE IS THE SHOE PINCHING?

– on the challenges associated with playful practices in exams on the social education programme

BY MIKKEL VINDING & SHOELACE

Mikkel Vinding, Associate Professor and PhD at University College South Denmark. This article is based on Vinding's PhD project: "Det kan være, det ikke passer ind i billedet" Om udfordringer ved at bruge legende tilgange i prøver på pædagoguddannelsen set i et relationelt pædagogisk perspektiv: En ph.d.-afhandling. ("It May Not Fit the Picture" – Challenges of Using Playful Approaches in Exams in the Social Education Programmes in a Relational Pedagogical Perspective: A PhD Dissertation).

What you are going to read now is a conversation between me and Shoelace. Shoelace is my youngest daughter's teddy, which was sitting next to me while I wrote this chapter. Shoelace has been my dialogue partner in the process, and with his name (my daughter chose it herself) and his burgeoning interest in philosophy, he also serves as a link to my research and the dissemination of my findings.

MIKKEL: In the following, I'm going to present my PhD dissertation. I have investigated the challenges associated with playful practices in exams on the social education programme from the perspective of relational pedagogics. More specifically, I have focused on electives and the exam in Nature & Outdoor Activities. Initially, I will discuss some of my findings. Then I will briefly describe how –

SHOELACE: Hey, not so fast! That's a pretty strange title and a pretty strange focus. Why do you focus on challenges?

MIKKEL: Good question. This is because existing research shows that the use of playful practices in higher education is challenged by performance-oriented educational thinking and practices. The way I see things, certain challenges exist that we need to recognise and try to understand at a very concrete level on the social education programmes in Denmark. And at the same time, I see the exam situation as a place where prevalent educational thinking and practices are condensed, and where things – so to speak – come to a head. Exams are therefore interesting because they can serve as a special lens to help us understand some of the fundamental challenges associated with playful practices in exams. With reference to Kierkegaard, you could say that I don't want to write about the Galoshes of Fortune, but rather about the pinching shoe.

SHOELACE: Very well, very well, but if we already know about the challenges associated with playful practices in higher education, then why do you want to spend more time on it?

MIKKEL: You could say that I'm not seeking to arrive at the same results, but that I'm using our existing knowledge as a basis for investigating how exams, understood as a *pedagogical practice*, are shaped by performance-oriented educational thinking and practices, and what this means for the use of playful practices. That is my special research interest.

SHOELACE: Meaning?

MIKKEL: It means that I'm interested in trying to understand exams as a pedagogical practice and on that basis identify some challenges. In this way, my research must be seen on an overall level in light of a pedagogical research interest. Theoretically, I'm inspired by, among other things, the skeptical turn in evaluation (Dahler-Larsen, 2019) and relational evaluation in education, which also presents important pedagogical perspectives

(Gergen & Gill, 2020). Both can serve as an analytical lens in relation to understanding and addressing current educational and evaluation thinking and practices as well as the challenges entailed for the use of playful practices in exams. And in addition, I'm inspired –

SHOELACE: So what did you find out?

MIKKEL: A little patience, Shoelace, please. But okay. Through my research, I found that the challenges associated with playful practices in exams are linked to several areas: These are focus on goal attainment, educational life forms, relations during exams and the epistemology of exams, the understandings and articulations of playfulness.

SHOELACE: Is that it?

MIKKEL: Yes, there are probably more, but these were the areas that stood out most clearly in my research. If it's okay with you, I'd like to explain a little more about the results of my research now.

SHOELACE: Okay.

MIKKEL: Great. Since our time is limited, I will not go through the above areas slavishly, but I will try to weave some of the findings and points together. That way, our conversation will also flow better, I think. I will start with one of the conclusions, which I've formulated in a more poetic form based on my analyses:

Words persuade the clockwork.
A well-dressed messenger rushes down the
main street, shouting a clear message about what is to come.
We pick up the fossils of the future,
and horizons begin to grow from the back of our heads.
They hide our eyes in a place we
can no longer quite remember.

A break-in to the beginnings of time.
And in the meantime, playful hands get out a raincoat
rather than trying to topple the clouds.

SHOELACE: It didn't make me any wiser.

MIKKEL: I understand. Explanation to follow. The language of the poem is very condensed, which fragments our understanding. You could say that the language creates a distance to itself and its own genre that allows us to relate to it and be mindful of it. Be mindful of its reach. Be mindful of the scope of research. That said, the conclusion will hopefully make more sense when we're done talking. But, for example, when I talk about playful hands getting out a raincoat, what I'm talking about are the fundamental challenges associated with incorporating playful practices in exams. The question is how to deal with it. Should we change our ways and adapt our playful designs to current educational thinking and practices with all the contradictory compromises that this may require, or should we instead 'rebel' and try to topple the clouds to allow playfulness to truly unfold?

SHOELACE: Okay. Go on. You have to make it more concrete for me.

MIKKEL: I thought I had, Shoelace, but okay. Through my research, a picture has emerged of a strong focus on goal attainment in connection with the exams. This

became evident, for example, in an interview with a student who was telling me how they had prepared for their exam as a group. The student said: "Because before the exam, we were like going through everything, what we had noted down about what we were going to say [...] are we making sure to mention a bit about this, and a bit about that – to make sure we were covering everything. So if the [playful] practices had been mentioned in [the goal(s)], then we would definitely have included them even more." The quote shows that a narrow focus on goal attainment gets in the way of playfulness. However, it was not only the students who were strongly focused on goal attainment. The educator, who had introduced the students to playful practices on the Nature & Outdoor Activities course, and who was later to act as examiner, was also strongly focused on the goals. This can be seen, for example, from the following quote, which I wrote down as a fieldnote during my observation of the guidance provided by the educator in the run-up to the exams. The educator/examiner said: "The competency goal should be kept in mind the whole time. Read it morning and evening. The knowledge and skills goals – those you can read at lunchtime."

SHOELACE: What is that a sign of?

MIKKEL: Well, it can be a sign of many different things. For example, it can be a sign that the educator is loyal to the grading scale order, which focuses on the degree of goal attainment.

SHOELACE: But is the grading scale a problem?

MIKKEL: It depends on what you want and what you find valuable. If you want exams to allow room for unpredictable, transgressive and disruptive elements, all of which can be linked to the qualities of play, then it is a problem in the sense that it does not accommodate any overpassing of the goals. And that can get in the way of playfulness.

SHOELACE: Okay. But what does all this have to do with, for example, future fossils, as you mentioned earlier?

MIKKEL: Well, you see ... In order to understand how goal orientedness – as a reflection of performance-oriented educational thinking and practices – shapes exams as a pedagogical practice, I have articulated the concept: the *memory of the future*, amongst others inspired by Thomassen (2001). You could say that the concept describes a more general educational logic that has a bearing on exams. With the *memory-of-the-future* concept, I point out, among other things, how the future is defined in advance (based on the goals) and in this way becomes a memory. This locks in the educational horizon, leading to a form of educational fatalism. The *memory of the future* also entails the existence of a normativity that is at the same time crystal-clear and blurred.

SHOELACE: Great if you could elaborate a bit on this last point. What do you mean by that?

MIKKEL: Well, on the one hand, the goals get a lot of attention and serve as clear benchmarks in connection with the exams. In this way, the goals are very evidently normative. But on the other hand, not many or fundamentally critical questions are asked about the goals themselves and their relevance, and in this way the normativity is blurred, resulting in a kind of naturalisation of the focus on goal attainment. As a pedagogical consequence of this, a form of aspect blindness, a notion developed by the philosopher of language Wittgenstein, can arise. This means that it becomes difficult to see more

than one aspect of reality and to alternatingly turn one's attention to different aspects. One's focus is exclusively on the goals, and as a result it becomes difficult to ask fundamental questions about the direction one wants to take and the desirability of this. In my perspective, the ability to turn your attention alternatingly to different aspects and ask value questions is crucial and defining for our pedagogical practice.

SHOELACE: Taking us back to exams as a pedagogical practice.

MIKKEL: Exactly. The pedagogical value perspective comes under pressure. This makes it difficult to justify the use of playful practices outside the *memory of the future*, which can lead to an instrumental understanding and application of such practices. This is evident, for example, in an interview where Simon, a student, talks about playful practices and associates it with being able to "[...] demonstrate these practices with 100 per cent efficiency" at the exam. The challenge is that the use of playful practices in exams is not anchored in strong and value-oriented pedagogical language and language play; on the contrary, as I just mentioned, it is left to the *memory of the future*.

SHOELACE: Well, I've heard actually that in connection with the Playful Learning development project, people want to find new ways and see goal orientedness as a challenge. So why is that?

MIKKEL: Good question. There are several factors at play. Firstly, even finding a suitable language for talking about playfulness can be hard. Playfulness in itself is not easily conceptualisable, and also, it's early days for research in this field. Secondly, through my research, I have realised that finding the time to prepare the students properly, in terms of imparting knowledge about playful practices, is a challenge. Several of the students I have talked to were keen to know more about it. In an interview with a group of students, Josefine said: "I'd like to have more knowledge. I think she [the educator/examiner] has succeeded in making me interested [...] But I don't think we acquired much knowledge about it." In the same interview, Agnes followed up: "You know, why it's a good thing and things like that." The lack of knowledge about playful practices led to unclear understandings and articulations of playfulness – in connection with the exams. Thus, playfulness did not come with a counter-language to that of the *memory of the future*, and therefore the use of playful practices could in a certain sense be seen as a language-less adaptation strategy or performative complicitness. I mean this in the sense that at the exams, playful activities were mainly used as minor transitional elements (for example, a song) and to illustrate concrete practices (for example, a group of students performing a role-play sequence to demonstrate how they would engage in an activity with a group of children) inspired by goal orientedness.

SHOELACE: It's a paradox.

MIKKEL: Indeed it is, especially in view of the wishes and ambitions of the Playful Learning development project. But of course, most students had no experience of using playful practices, and also the educational life forms at the time generally fuelled the students' doubts about using playful practices in exams. Such doubts were expressed, for example, by a student, who said that it feels "more grown-up, if you can say so, to be presenting in front of a PowerPoint." Also, one of the educators explained how playful practices can have the outward appearance of more

break-like elements. Both examples point to sources of doubt about the use of playful practices, and it was precisely such doubts that led some students to opt out of using playful elements. You could say that playfulness was not ascribed an immediate and strong meaning within the framework of the educational life forms in connection with the exams, and in this way the use of playful practices became person-dependent. In other words: It became dependent on the presence of an educator/examiner who could attribute value and meaning to playfulness in spite of the life forms. In addition, it became dependent on the presence of an external examiner who was open to playful practices and for whom they were meaningful.

SHOELACE: So using playful practices in exams is not without risks.

MIKKEL: No, you can say that.

SHOELACE: But how did the external examiners take it? Did they play along?

MIKKEL: The external examiners I talked to expressed an interest in using playful practices, so it was not as if they actively resisted or opposed the idea during the exams. But looking at the exams in a broader perspective, relations between the students and the examiners/external examiners during the exams were a challenge. For two reasons mainly. Firstly, the students were told explicitly that they were the ones who had to be active during the exam. For example, their educator/examiner said at one point: "It's not me and the external examiner who are being examined. It is for you to be active." This created a distance between the examinees and the examiners, who took on audience and spectator roles. Secondly –

SHOELACE: Wait a minute. What's the problem with distance?

MIKKEL: There are a number of problems. Among other things, it makes it difficult for the students to introduce playful designs. For example, one student I interviewed said that "playfulness is difficult because of course we shouldn't involve [...] the external examiner etc. in it." Students can feel exposed if they are expected to bring playfulness into play, while being observed. And another important point is probably that when the examiners take on the roles of audience and spectators, it is left to the students to dare the unpredictable during the exams, while the examiners keep a safe distance.

SHOELACE: I understand. What was the second thing you were about to say? Sorry for interrupting.

MIKKEL: Where was I ... Well, secondly, relations during the exams were sometimes a challenge, as the whole focus was on the individual student rather than focusing on a broader dialogue. For example, according to one of my fieldnotes, at an exam a student by the name of Simon tried to add to something another student had said. But the external examiner stopped him, saying: "Now this is a discussion." The external examiner puts up his hands, palms facing Simon, to stop him. Despite the fact that the exam has moved in the direction of a discussion, the external examiner is more interested in the individual student's knowledge and performance in isolation. However, this focus on the individual student must also be seen in a wider perspective, as it is reflected in the grading scale order in connection with the exams. And I know what you're going to ask now, Shoelace: But why is focusing on the individual student at exams such a problem?

SHOELACE: We know each other well!

MIKKEL: Well, you see ... This is a challenge because of the social aspects of playfulness, which are accorded no value if knowledge is regarded as being possessed by the individual. The challenges associated with distance and the focus on the individual can be seen as epistemological features of the exams, which follow from an individual-centred educational tradition.

SHOELACE: So the challenges really go quite deep.

MIKKEL: Yes. In any case, it is important to be aware of the opportunities as well as the barriers to the use of playful practices created by our educational thinking, practices and policies.

SHOELACE: But is there nothing you can do?

MIKKEL: It depends on what you want and what you think it is worth striving and working for when it comes to education, our pedagogical practices and the use of playful approaches. You remember the raincoat. In my dissertation, I have formulated a number of post hoc design principles, offering suggestions as to how one could support the use of playful practices and strengthen the exams as a pedagogical practice.

SHOELACE: So the solution is?

MIKKEL: There's no solution as such, and that's also why I only mention the design principles now. In my approach to research, I draw on design-based research (Christensen et al., 2012), but to me, a crucial and perhaps also sometimes overlooked point is that with design-based research, you can end up focusing on superficial problems that you find solutions to rather than identifying and insisting on more fundamental challenges, which may, in fact, contribute more learning (Buhl et al., 2022, p. 208). It is in this light that I project the design principles into the future.

SHOELACE: Which is about?

MIKKEL: Which, among other things, is about being able to enter into dialogue about what you find pedagogically valuable in the context of exams, how to interpret the goals of exams when playfulness is not mentioned specifically, and how you – consciously or unconsciously – contribute to shaping exams as a pedagogical practice with the way you enter into relations. This is an important message. And with this, I address some of the challenges I have identified, but I do not come up with a solution, and basically I'm setting the stage for local dialogue in connection with the design principles. Research does not own the language, and there are always local expressions, traditions and values at play that I do not want to underestimate.

SHOELACE: So it's "back to the rough ground!" (Wittgenstein, 2009, p. 51e, #107).

MIKKEL: Thanks. Yes, it is probably a matter of keeping up the dialogue and lacing up our shoes so that together we can step into a future that is not already gone. And it's a future that's filled with both mud and morning.

A 20-finger flicker stretches the
tissue across a no-man's-land
and small beginnings break out of the stones
on the other side of order,
the pupils of the eye dance in mud and morning

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BACKG


ROUND

Playful Learning Research Extension (2019-2024) is a research project funded by the LEGO Foundation and the six university colleges in Denmark. The research project is a part of the Playful Learning Programme and has been headed by Kolding School of Design and with participation from University College Northern Denmark, VIA University College, University College South Denmark, UCL University College, University College Absalon and University College Copenhagen as well as Aalborg University and the Danish School of Education at Aarhus University.

The research project consists of 12 PhD students and 10 senior researchers who have collaborated on the themes of cultural change, materiality and space as well as didactics. The project has also included a survey into the effect of playful approaches for students as well as educators on the social education and teacher education programmes.

The research project have complied with the Danish Code of Conduct for Research Integrity, respecting the principles of honesty, transparency and accountability, and adopted an arm's length principle in the collaboration with the LEGO Foundation. This means, among other things, that the PhD projects have been formulated, realised and completed with the PhD students' interests and competences as the springboard, and that the other initiatives have been formulated and realised with the researchers' interests and competences as a driving force.

How can play contribute to teaching in social education and teacher education programmes?

In this publication, you will find 12 perspectives on playful learning in social education and teacher education programmes in Denmark. The 12 perspectives have been written by 12 PhD students in Playful Learning's research project (2019-2024), who have explored how play qualities strengthen and challenge teaching in the programmes.

Through 12 articles focusing on cultural change, learning spaces and didactics, you get insight into how educators work with play and how play contributes to future social educators and teachers' professions. The articles are intended as inspiration for social education and teacher education programmes, where the core question of play—*what if*?—paves the way for future social educators and teachers.

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